SYSTEMS THINKING & B2B MARKETING

PROJECT 4

Strategic Consulting Preparation Report

Health & Sports Nutrition Industry

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Programme: HBO Digital Business Concept

University: Fontys University of Applied Sciences

Project: Project 4 Systems Thinking & B2B Marketing

Submission Date: 22 June 2026

Academic Year: 2025–2026



Strategic Consulting Client: Upfront (Rotterdam, Netherlands)

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Chapters 4 –7 are individual work by Manar Alsadi

Fontys

Introduction

This report is submitted as the individual final deliverable for Project 4: Systems Thinking and B2B Marketing, part of the HBO Digital Business Concept programme at Fontys University of Applied Sciences. The project runs over six weeks and is designed to prepare students for the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project by developing skills in systems thinking, B2B sales strategy, stakeholder analysis, and strategic problem formulation.

The report is structured in seven chapters, each building on the previous. Chapters 1 and 2 apply systems thinking to the textile and fast-fashion industry as a group exercise, developing foundational analytical skills in problem mapping, causal loop diagramming, and the Iceberg Model. From Chapter 3 onwards, the analysis shifts to a self-selected industry the Health and Sports Nutrition sector which was chosen for its rich systemic sustainability challenges and its direct relevance to a real-world Dutch D2C brand, Upfront, selected as the strategic consulting target. Chapters 3 through 6 are individual work.

The central argument of this report is that the health and sports nutrition industry is caught in a fundamental paradox: it markets itself on health, transparency, and wellness, yet its supply chain relies on carbon-intensive dairy protein, non-recyclable composite plastic packaging, and unverified green marketing claims. This paradox creates an urgent strategic opportunity for brands like Upfront that are structurally positioned to lead the transition to verified sustainability if they act before regulatory enforcement deadlines and better-resourced competitors close the window.

Chapter 4 selects three companies Upfront, Basic-Fit, and Ekoplaza and formulates 30 testable assumptions grounded in desk research. Chapter 5 maps the Decision-Making Unit for each company, develops a targeted B2B contact strategy, and applies the SPIN selling methodology to the two most strategically critical contacts. Chapter 6 validates the assumptions through triangulated desk research and formulates a well-argued strategic consulting question for Upfront. Chapter 7 reflects on individual and team functioning during the project.

All sources are cited in APA format, and the full references list is provided at the end of this report. Academic writing conventions have been followed throughout, with the exception of this introduction and Chapter 7 (reflection), which are written in the first person as permitted by the Week 6 briefing.

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Chapter 1: Understand The System

This report, developed for Project 4 (Systems Thinking and B2B Marketing), serves as a foundational exercise for Year 2 Strategic Consulting. It utilizes the textile industry as a primary case study. The textile sector itself is a massive global sector generating approximately $1 trillion annually, accounting for 7% of total global exports, and employing over 35 million people worldwide (Desore & Narula, 2018). By synthesizing kickoff presentation insights with individual desk research, this chapter builds the groundwork for future system mapping, exploring the root causes of fast fashion and analyzing the strategic challenges and opportunities for actors across the supply chain.

1.1 Problem Mapping & Desk Research Summary

During the project's kickoff, it was established that "systems thinking" focuses on understanding how different actors, stakeholders, suppliers, policies, consumers, and companies are interconnected inside one system (Fontys University of Applied Sciences, 2026). The fast-fashion industry is a prime example of a highly interconnected global system; decisions made by fashion brands directly influence manufacturers, consumers, transport companies, recycling systems, and even agricultural production. Because all actors are linked, one problem in the system creates multiple environmental, economic, and social consequences across the entire chain (European Commission, 2024).

The Scale of Overconsumption and Waste

The contemporary textile industry operates on a linear "use and dispose" framework (Alves et al., 2021). Currently, the average consumer's closet contains 172 clothing items, yet approximately 79% of these garments are never worn (Fontys University of Applied Sciences, 2026). This relentless cycle is heavily driven by psychological factors, dopamine-driven "retail therapy," and manipulative marketing tactics on platforms like TikTok and Instagram (Åbo Akademi University, 2025; Ritch, 2021). Consequently, the lifespan of products has drastically decreased, with 50% of fast fashion being thrown away within just one year of purchase (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2017). Globally, the industry generates an estimated 92 million tons of textile waste per year (Chen et al., 2021).

The Environmental Toll

The rapid production of textiles places a severe burden on the global environment, with the fashion sector responsible for 8 to 10% of worldwide CO2 emissions (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Furthermore,

the industry is the second-largest consumer of water globally (European Parliament, 2020). Producing a single cotton T-shirt requires 2,700 liters of water, heavily contributing to water scarcity in agricultural regions (World Wildlife Fund, 2013). The heavy reliance on synthetic materials exacerbates this issue; washing synthetic clothing releases an estimated 500,000 tons of microplastics annually, accounting for 35% of all primary microplastics found in the ocean (European Environment Agency, 2022).

The Social and Human Cost

The artificially low consumer prices that fuel fast fashion are sustained by unethical labor practices (Bick et al., 2018). The reliance on cheap, unskilled labor in periphery nations often traps garment workers and agricultural laborers in the Global South in extreme poverty (Alves et al., 2021). For example, garment workers in Bangladesh earn drastically below the estimated livable income, and occupational safety standards are often weakly enforced, exposing workers to debilitating health and safety hazards daily (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024).

1.2 Causes and Consequences of Fast Fashion

Understanding the root causes and consequences of the fast-fashion crisis is essential for identifying strategic intervention points. Below, the project team has individually mapped distinct causes and impacts based on targeted desk research.

1.2.1 Individual Analysis: Anna van Rijsoort

The 5 causes of the fast-fashion crisis include:

1. **Overproduction cycles**

   Brands release new collections weekly, pushing constant novelty and flooding the market with cheap clothing. (A New Textiles Economy: Redesigning Fashion’s Future, 2017)

2. **Lack of recycling infrastructure**

   Less than 1% of garments are recycled in a closed loop, largely because blended fabrics (polyester-cotton mixes) cannot be separated by existing mechanical recycling technology. (A New Textiles Economy: Redesigning Fashion’s Future, 2017)

3. **Greenwashing undermines informed choice**

   Brands use vague terms like "eco", "conscious" or "sustainable collection" without independent verification, misleading consumers who want to make better choices. A 2021 European Commission study found 42% of green claims online were exaggerated or outright false - meaning well-intentioned shoppers are actively misled (European Commission, 2021).

4. **Weak labor protections**

   Production is outsourced to countries with low wages, unsafe conditions, and limited worker rights (Reichart, 2019).

5. **Consumer demand for trends**

   Social media, influencers, and platforms like Shein accelerate trend turnover and encourage overconsumption (Reichart, 2019).

Moreover, 5 consequences of fast fashion include:

1. **Massive CO_2 emissions**

   The textile industry accounts for 8–10% of global greenhouse gas emissions more than international aviation and maritime shipping combined (UNEP, 2018).

2. **Severe water depletion and pollution**

   Textile production is the second largest industrial water user globally and responsible for 20% of global water pollution through dye runoff and chemical discharge. Producing one T-shirt requires 2,700 liters of water (UNEP, 2018).

3. **Microplastic contamination**

   Washing synthetic garments releases 500,000 tones of microplastics into waterways annually. These have been detected in oceans, drinking water, fish, and now human blood and placentas. (Ragusa, A. et al., 2021)

4. **Labor exploitation and poverty wages**

   The drive for ever-cheaper production pushes wages down. In Bangladesh, garment workers earn roughly €80/month against a livable income benchmark of €368/month. Child labor affects an estimated 250 million children in the textile sector globally. (International Labour Organization, 2026).

5. **Enormous textile waste**

   73% of clothing ends up landfilled or incinerated. The EU alone generates 8 million tones of textile waste per year around 18 kg per person with less than 1% recycled back into new clothing. (European Environment Agency, 2022)

1.2.2 Individual Analysis: Amira Kartika Rochman

The 5 causes of the fast-fashion crisis include:

1. **Psychological Manipulation and Micro-Trends**

   Algorithmic "micro-trends" trigger impulsive, dopamine-driven consumption, shifting shopping from a necessity to an emotional reflex (Ritch, 2021).

2. **Planned Obsolescence in Production**

   Brands intentionally utilize low-quality, highly degradable materials to ensure garments wear out quickly, forcing frequent repurchasing (Åbo Akademi University, 2025).

3. **Technological Limitations in Recycling**

   The heavy reliance on multicomponent blended fabrics (such as polyester-cotton blends) makes commercial-scale closed-loop recycling technologically and economically unviable, preventing the industry from achieving true circularity (Yang et al., 2024).

4. **Lack of Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR)**

   Without Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) frameworks, brands face no financial consequences for the end-of-life disposal of their products, removing incentives for durable design (Jones & Leonas, 2023).

5. **Opaque and Fragmented Supply Chains**

   Extreme fragmentation allows major retail brands to demand artificially low production costs while dodging accountability for the resulting environmental and ethical violations (Bick et al., 2018).

Moreover, 5 consequences of fast fashion include:

1. **Global Waste Exportation Hazards:**

   Massive volumes of unmanageable textile waste are exported to low- and middle-income nations, creating severe ecological and public health crises (Bick et al., 2018).

2. **Acceleration of Climate Change**

   Energy-intensive mass production makes fashion one of the most polluting industries globally, responsible for 8 to 10% of total worldwide carbon emissions (Niinimäki et al., 2020).

3. **Severe Groundwater Depletion**

   Industrial over-extraction for water-intensive crops like cotton has caused local water tables in textile manufacturing hubs to collapse, leaving local communities with severe water scarcity (Healthy Materials Lab, n.d.)

4. **Marine Microplastic Pollution**

   The mass adoption of cheap synthetic fibers has resulted in catastrophic water pollution as washing synthetic fast fashion garments releases an estimated 500,000 tons of microplastics into the ocean annually (European Environment Agency, 2022).

5. **Perpetuation of Exploitative Labor and Poverty**

   To sustain artificially low retail prices, the industry systematically traps garment workers and agricultural laborers in the Global South in cycles of extreme poverty, frequently exposing them to hazardous conditions and relying heavily on child labor (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024; International Labour Organization, 2016).

1.2.3 Individual Analysis: Lydia Sagri

The 5 causes of the fast-fashion crisis include:

1. **Mass Production of Low Cost Apparel**

   The fast fashion model is predicated on the mass production of low-cost clothing designed for rapid replacement rather than longevity (Olivar Aponte, N., Hernández Gómez, J., Torres Argüelles, V., & Smith, E. D, 2024*).*

2. **Social Media Influence and FOMO**

   Platforms like Instagram and TikTok accelerate trend cycles through "see now, buy now" styles, while the psychological "fear of missing out" (FOMO) sustains continuous consumer demand (Olivar Aponte, N., Hernández Gómez, J., Torres Argüelles, V., & Smith, E. D, 2024*).*

3. **Exploitation of Low-Wage Labor**

   The industry relies heavily on the availability of cheap, unskilled labor in periphery nations to produce garments at a large scale (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

4. **Shift from Needs to Luxuries**

   Consumer behavior has shifted from purchasing based on necessity to purchasing for wants and perceived status, treating fashion as a ritual for peer acceptance (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

5. **Adoption of Synthetic Fibers**

   Approximately 70% of fast fashion garments are made from synthetic materials like polyester and nylon derived from fossil fuels, which are inexpensive to produce (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

Moreover, 5 consequences of fast fashion include:

1. **Extreme Water Consumption and Pollution**

   Textile production consumes roughly 93 billion cubic meters of water annually, with dyeing and finishing processes serving as the second-largest source of freshwater pollution globally (Bildirici, M., Türkkahraman, I., & Ersin, Ö. 2024).

2. **Massive Textile Waste Generation**

   The industry generates over 92 million tons of textile waste each year, much of which ends up in landfills or is burned as "dead stock" (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

3. **Microplastic Contamination**

   Roughly 35% of all microplastics in the ocean originate from the laundering of synthetic fast fashion textiles (Olivar Aponte, N., Hernández Gómez, J., Torres Argüelles, V., & Smith, E. D, 2024).

4. **Social Injustice and Labor Abuse**

   Production is often outsourced to regions with minimal regulation, leading to wage theft and unsafe working conditions (Bildirici, M., Türkkahraman, I., & Ersin, Ö. 2024).

5. **Waste Colonization of the Global South**

   Large volumes of discarded clothing are exported to the Global South, where they saturate local markets and cause significant environmental degradation (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

1.2.4 Individual Analysis: Manar Alsadi

The 5 causes of the fast-fashion crisis include:

6. **Cheap clothing prices**

   Fast-fashion brands intentionally keep prices artificially low to maximize purchase frequency. Between 2000 and 2014, global clothing production doubled while the average price consumers paid decreased significantly, enabling people to buy more items than ever before (UNEP, 2023). This low-price model is only possible because environmental and social costs are externalized onto workers, communities, and ecosystems rather than reflected in the retail price a phenomenon known as "true pricing" (European Commission, 2024).

7. **Social media and algorithmic trend acceleration**

   Social media platforms and influencers continuously promote new micro-trends, compressing fashion cycles from seasons to weeks. Platforms like TikTok generate what researchers call "algorithmic micro-trends," triggering dopamine-driven purchasing impulses that shift shopping from a considered decision to an emotional reflex (Ritch, 2021). Shein, for example, adds between 2,000 and 10,000 new products to its platform every single day, a volume only possible through this constant social-media-driven demand cycle (European Environment Agency, 2024).

8. **Easy online shopping and frictionless payment services**

   The rise of one-click purchasing, same-day delivery, and Buy Now Pay Later (BNPL) services such as Klarna and Afterpay have systematically removed the psychological friction that once slowed purchasing decisions. BNPL usage in Europe grew by over 40% between 2020 and 2022, particularly among younger consumers aged 18–34, directly correlating with increased impulse fashion purchases (European Commission, 2024). By deferring payment, these services psychologically decouple the act of buying from its financial consequences, further fueling overconsumption.

9. **Outsourcing production to low-wage countries**

   Global fashion brands systematically relocate manufacturing to countries with the lowest possible labor costs and weakest regulatory enforcement. In Bangladesh the world's second-largest garment exporter the minimum wage is approximately €80 per month, far below the estimated living wage of €368 per month (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024). This structural cost-shifting allows brands to maintain high profit margins while effectively transferring environmental and human costs onto vulnerable communities in the Global South (European Environment Agency, 2024).

10. **Short product lifecycles by design**

Fast-fashion brands deliberately use low-quality, highly degradable materials as a form of planned obsolescence, ensuring garments wear out quickly and must be replaced frequently (Åbo Akademi University, 2025). The average number of times a garment is worn before being discarded has decreased by 36% since 2000, and approximately 50% of fast-fashion items are thrown away within a single year of purchase (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2017). Rather than reflecting poor quality as a flaw, brands strategically design this into the product to sustain perpetual repurchase cycles.

Moreover, 5 consequences of fast fashion include:

6. **Massive CO_2 emissions and climate acceleration**

   The textile industry is responsible for 8 to 10% of global greenhouse gas emissions more than the combined emissions of international aviation and maritime shipping (Niinimäki et al., 2020). Energy-intensive spinning, dyeing, and finishing processes, predominantly powered by coal in manufacturing hubs across Asia, make fashion one of the most carbon-intensive industries on the planet. Without systemic intervention, the fashion industry's carbon footprint is projected to increase by a further 50% by 2030 (UNEP, 2023).

7. **Enormous and growing textile waste**

   The global fashion industry generates approximately 92 million tons of textile waste annually, with 73% of all clothing ultimately ending up in landfills or incinerated (Chen et al., 2021). Within the European Union alone, each person discards an average of 18 kg of textiles per year, and less than 1% is recycled back into new clothing (European Environment Agency, 2022). This waste crisis is directly driven by the overproduction model: brands deliberately produce far more garments than are sold, burning or landfilling unsold "dead stock" to maintain artificial scarcity and brand image (UNEP, 2023).

8. **Microplastic contamination of water systems**

   Every time a synthetic garment is washed, it sheds thousands of microscopic plastic fibers directly into wastewater systems. Globally, washing synthetic clothing releases an estimated 500,000 tons of microplastics annually, accounting for 35% of all primary microplastics found in the ocean (European Environment Agency, 2022). These particles are now detected not only in marine ecosystems but also in human blood, lung tissue, and placentas, raising serious public health concerns (Ragusa et al., 2021). As approximately 70% of fast-fashion garments are made from synthetic fibers, this problem scales directly with production volumes.

9. **Severe labour exploitation and poverty wages**

   The relentless pressure to reduce production costs is transferred directly onto garment workers. In Bangladesh, the minimum wage sits at approximately €80 per month, less than a quarter of the estimated living wage of €368 per month (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024).

Globally, an estimated 250 million children are engaged in labor within the textile sector, particularly in cotton farming and dyeing processes (International Labour Organization, 2016). The 2013 Rana Plaza factory collapse in Bangladesh which killed 1,134 garment workers remains the starkest symbol of how prioritizing cost reduction over human safety produces fatal systemic outcomes (International Labour Organization, 2016).

10. **Systemic overconsumption and normalized disposability**

    Fast fashion has fundamentally restructured consumer behavior by normalizing the idea that clothing is disposable. The average consumer's wardrobe now contains approximately 172 clothing items, yet only around 21% of these garments are actually worn on a regular basis (Fontys University of Applied Sciences, 2026). This overconsumption is not accidental; it is the intended outcome of a business model that profits from volume rather than value. The systemic result is a culture of waste in which purchasing has replaced wearing as the primary relationship between consumers and clothing.

1.2.5 Individual Analysis: Yareni Hernandez Jimenez

The 5 causes of the fast-fashion crisis include:

1. **Rapid Trend Cycles and Social Media Influence**

   Social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram accelerate fashion trends and encourage consumers to continuously purchase new clothing to remain fashionable. Influencer culture and "haul" content normalize excessive consumption and short product usage cycles (European Environment Agency, 2025).

2. **Low Production Costs**

   Fast-fashion companies reduce production costs by outsourcing manufacturing to countries where labor and operational costs are significantly lower. This allows brands to sell clothing at extremely cheap prices while maintaining profitability **(**Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024).

3. **Cheap Synthetic Materials**

   Many fast-fashion garments are produced using inexpensive synthetic fibers such as polyester and nylon. These materials are affordable and easy to mass-produce, but they are fossil-fuel based and contribute to environmental pollution (European Environment Agency, 2022).

4. **Consumer Culture and Impulse Buying**

Modern consumer culture increasingly connects identity and social status to purchasing behavior. Constant discounts, online shopping, and fast delivery services encourage impulse purchases and excessive clothing consumption (UNEP, 2023).

5. **Lack of Circular Production Systems**

   Most fast-fashion products are not designed for recycling, repair, or long-term use. The absence of effective circular systems means that clothing is often discarded after limited use instead of being reused or recycled efficiently (European Environment Agency, 2025).

Moreover, 5 consequences of fast fashion include:

1. **Environmental Pollution**

   Textile production contributes significantly to greenhouse gas emissions, water contamination, and chemical pollution. Dyeing and finishing processes release hazardous substances into ecosystems and require large amounts of water and energy (UNEP, 2023).

2. **Massive Textile Waste**

   The fashion industry generates millions of tons of textile waste annually because clothing is frequently discarded after minimal use. Many garments end up in landfills or are incinerated instead of recycled (European Environment Agency, 2025).

3. **Microplastic Contamination**

   Synthetic garments release microplastics during washing. These particles enter rivers and oceans, harming marine ecosystems and contributing to long-term environmental contamination (European Environment Agency, 2022).

4. **Exploitative Labour Conditions**

   Fast-fashion production is often linked to low wages, unsafe working conditions, and excessive overtime in some garment-producing countries. Workers are pressured to meet high production demands at minimal cost (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024).

5. **Resource Depletion**

   The industry consumes enormous quantities of water, energy, and raw materials. Cotton production alone requires large amounts of water, contributing to water scarcity in agricultural regions (UNEP, 2023).

1.3 Challenges and Opportunities

The transition from a linear "take-make-dispose" model to a circular economy presents distinct challenges and strategic opportunities for every stakeholder. To successfully intervene in the fast-fashion system as a B2B marketer or strategic consultant, it is essential to map the varying pressures and incentives driving the individual actors within the supply chain. Below, the project team individually analyzes these dynamics.

1.3.1 Individual Analysis: Anna van Rijsoort

1. Raw Material Producers (cotton farmers, fiber manufacturers)

Challenges: Conventional cotton farming uses enormous volumes of water and pesticides, degrading soil and local water supplies. Cotton covers 2.5% of global agricultural land but accounts for 16% of all insecticides used worldwide (Claydon, 2024).

Opportunities: Regenerative agriculture and organic cotton rebuild soil health and reduce chemical use. The organic cotton market grew 37% in 2021/22, showing rising commercial demand (Textile Exchange, 2022).

2. Textile Manufacturers (spinning, weaving, dyeing factories)

Challenges: Dyeing and finishing are among the most chemically intensive processes in any industry. The textile sector is responsible for 20% of global water pollution, largely through untreated dyeing wastewater entering local rivers. (UNEP. 2018)

Opportunities: Closed-loop water systems can reduce water consumption by up to 95% in dyeing processes. Designing fabrics as mono-materials from the outset makes future recycling far more feasible and is increasingly required under new EU regulations. European Environment Agency. (Textiles And The Environment: The Role Of Design in Europe's Circular Economy, 2022b)

3. Fashion Brands & Retailers

Challenges: The core business model depends on volume. Fashion production doubled between 2000 and 2015 while the number of times a garment is worn decreased by 36%. (A New Textiles Economy: Redesigning Fashion's Future, 2017b)

Opportunities: Circular business models rental, repair, resale and take-back schemes open new revenue streams. The global secondhand clothing market is projected to reach USD 350 billion by 2027, growing three times faster than the overall apparel market. (James Reinhart, thredUP CEO, 2023)

4. Logistics & Distribution

Challenges: Free returns generate enormous unnecessary transport emissions. In the UK alone, an estimated 25% of all online fashion purchases are returned, each generating additional carbon emissions. (ReBound Returns, 2025)

Opportunities: Near-shoring production reduces transport distances and improves supply chain resilience. A 2020 McKinsey study found nearshoring could reduce lead times by 40–50% while cutting transport emissions significantly. (McKinsey & Company. (2020)

1.3.2 Individual Analysis: Amira Kartika Rochman

1. Raw Material Producers (e.g., Cotton Farmers)

Challenge: Agricultural producers at the very bottom of the supply chain face intense margin pressures from global commodity markets, forcing a reliance on exploitative labor to maintain profitability (International Labour Organization, 2016). Furthermore, they are highly vulnerable to the climate crisis, facing severe water scarcity and soil degradation caused by their own intensive farming practices (Healthy Materials Lab, n.d.).

Opportunity: To combat these extreme economic pressures, smallholder farmers can form localized agricultural cooperatives. By grouping together, they gain the B2B bargaining power needed to bypass exploitative middlemen and negotiate guaranteed, fair prices directly with retail brands. This financial stability finally provides the capital they need to phase out child labor and invest in sustainable, drought-resistant farming.

2. Garment Manufacturers (Factory Owners)

Challenge: Major retail brands pressure manufacturers to produce clothing extremely fast and cheaply. These squeezed profit margins make it nearly impossible for factories to pay livable wages or provide safe working conditions (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024).

Opportunity: To counter the overwhelming power of global retail brands, manufacturers can form regional supplier coalitions. By collectively negotiating minimum purchasing prices, standardized lead times, and fair B2B contracts, factory owners can shift the power dynamic of the supply chain. This protects their profit margins while creating the financial stability necessary to actually provide livable wages and safe working conditions for their employees.

3. Retail Brands and Fast-Fashion Companies

Challenge: Upcoming EU regulations, specifically Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR), will force retail brands to pay for the recycling and disposal of their products. This legally threatens the profitability of producing high volumes of low-quality fast fashion (Jones & Leonas, 2023).

Opportunity: Brands must pivot from selling sheer volume to selling "services." Opportunities lie in adopting circular B2C business models, such as clothing rental subscriptions, brand-owned resale platforms, and repair services, which generate continuous revenue from a single garment while complying with upcoming eco-legislation.

4. Consumers (End-Users)

Challenge: Consumers are trapped in an algorithmic, dopamine-driven cycle of overconsumption normalized by ultra-fast fashion platforms (Åbo Akademi University, 2025). When trying to shop sustainably, they are frequently confronted with pervasive "greenwashing" by brands and a lack of affordable, genuinely sustainable alternatives (Ritch, 2021).

Opportunity: Consumers are gaining access to more transparent data, such as Digital Product Passports mandated by the EU, allowing them to make informed purchasing decisions. They have the opportunity to shift their behavior toward secondary markets, utilizing rapidly growing peer-to-peer resale platforms (like Vinted) to extend the lifespan of their garments.

5. Waste Management and Recycling Facilities

Challenge: Recyclers are overwhelmed by the sheer volume of discarded fast fashion. Technologically, they face massive bottlenecks because commercial-scale chemical separation of multicomponent blended fabrics (like polyester-cotton) remains incredibly difficult and expensive (de Lima et al., 2026).

Opportunity: As brands are forced to pay EPR fees, immense capital will flow into the waste management sector. Recycling facilities have a massive opportunity to use this funding to innovate and scale chemical recycling technologies, creating a highly profitable B2B revenue stream by selling premium recycled yarns back to garment manufacturers (Wang & Salmon, 2022).

1.3.3 Individual Analysis: Lydia Sagri

Challenges:

1. Supply Chain Complexity

The value chain is extremely fragmented across different countries, making it difficult to trace every activity and item (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

2. Linear Business Models

Most leading brands are still anchored to linear models that prioritize high turnover and resource depletion over circularity (Olivar Aponte, N., Hernández Gómez, J., Torres Argüelles, V., & Smith, E. D, 2024).

3. Chemical and Toxic Output

The "wet process" of manufacturing involves hazardous substances that require intensive treatment before water can be safely discharged (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

Opportunities:

1. Transition to a Circular Economy

There is a significant opportunity to "circularize" the value chain by using discarded clothing as raw material for new production (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

2. Technological Traceability

Implementing blockchain technology and IoT can help register activities across the value chain, creating the transparency necessary for consumer trust (Alves, L., Ferreira Cruz, E., Lopes, S. I., Faria, P. M., & Rosado da Cruz, A. M. 2021).

3. Renewable Raw Materials

Shifting toward renewable raw materials and rethinking production to maximize the reuse of textile products offers a pathway to survival in a "green circular economy" (Olivar Aponte, N., Hernández Gómez, J., Torres Argüelles, V., & Smith, E. D, 2024*).*

1.3.4 Individual Analysis: Manar Alsadi

1. Fashion Brands

Challenge: Pressure to reduce pollution and improve transparency in supply chains (EEA, 2024).

Opportunity: Development of sustainable fashion collections and circular business models (European Commission, 2024).

2. Manufacturers

Challenge: Rising production costs driven by incoming EU Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) regulations are forcing manufacturers to invest in cleaner processes, placing additional financial pressure on already thin margins (Jones & Leonas, 2023).

Opportunity: Investment in sustainable materials and cleaner production technologies (UNEP, 2023).

3. Retailers

Challenge: High return rates and overstock caused by fast fashion place significant financial and logistical burdens on retailers. In the UK, approximately 25% of all online fashion purchases are returned, generating unnecessary transport emissions and increasing waste (ReBound Returns, 2025).

Opportunity: Growth of second-hand fashion and sustainable product categories.

4. Logistics Companies

Challenge: Increased transportation emissions and reverse logistics from returns contribute significantly to the industry's carbon footprint. Global textile supply chains span multiple continents, and free return policies have further multiplied unnecessary transport cycles (UNEP, 2023).

Opportunity: Green logistics and more efficient delivery systems.

5. Recycling Companies

Challenge: Difficulty recycling mixed textile materials because recycling rates remain low (EEA, 2022).

Opportunity: Innovation in textile recycling technologies.

6. Governments

Challenge: Controlling pollution and labour violations globally.

Opportunity: Development of sustainability policies and circular economy strategies (Government of the Netherlands, 2024).

7. Consumers

Challenge: Fast-changing trends and overconsumption habits are deeply embedded through algorithmic marketing. Despite growing awareness, comfort, price, and brand recognition consistently outweigh environmental concerns in actual purchasing decisions (European Environment Agency, 2024).

Opportunity: Increased awareness of sustainable and ethical fashion.

8. Sustainable Startups

Challenge: Difficulty competing with artificially low fast-fashion prices is the primary barrier for sustainable startups. Because fast fashion externalizes environmental and social costs, sustainable brands which internalize these costs appear more expensive to consumers even when their true price is actually lower (European Commission, 2024).

Opportunity: Growing demand for eco-friendly and ethical products.

1.3.5 Individual Analysis: Yareni Hernandez Jimenez

1. Raw Material Producers

Challenge: Cotton farmers and raw material suppliers face pressure to produce large quantities of materials at very low prices. Intensive agricultural practices contribute to soil degradation, pesticide use, and water scarcity.

Opportunity: Sustainable farming methods such as organic cotton production, regenerative agriculture, and water-efficient irrigation systems can reduce environmental impact while improving long-term agricultural sustainability.

2. Garment Manufacturers

Challenge: Manufacturers are pressured by fashion brands to produce clothing rapidly and cheaply. This often reduces factory profit margins and increases pressure on workers.

Opportunity: Factories can invest in cleaner technologies, ethical labor standards, and sustainable production methods. Collaboration with sustainable brands may create more stable and transparent business relationships.

3. Fashion Brands and Retailers

Challenge: Fashion brands face growing criticism regarding overproduction, waste generation, and lack of supply-chain transparency. New EU sustainability regulations also increase pressure on companies to improve environmental performance.

Opportunity: Brands can adopt circular business models such as resale, rental, repair services, and recyclable product design. Sustainable innovation can improve brand image and customer loyalty.

4. Logistics Companies

Challenge: Global textile supply chains rely heavily on transportation, contributing to carbon emissions and environmental pollution. High return rates from online shopping also increase transport-related emissions.

Opportunity: Logistics companies can invest in greener transportation systems, optimized delivery routes, and low-emission technologies to reduce environmental impact.

5. Recycling Companies

Challenge: Textile recycling remains difficult because many garments contain blended materials that are hard to separate and process effectively.

Opportunity: Advances in textile sorting systems and recycling technologies create opportunities for innovation and circular economy development within the textile industry.

6. Governments and Regulators

Challenge: Governments face difficulties regulating global supply chains and enforcing sustainability standards internationally.

Opportunity: Policies such as Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR), circular economy regulations, and sustainability reporting requirements can encourage more responsible industry practices.

7. Consumers

Challenge: Consumers are continuously exposed to fast-changing trends and aggressive marketing strategies that encourage overconsumption.

Opportunity: Consumers increasingly support second-hand fashion, ethical brands, and sustainable consumption habits. Growing environmental awareness may help reduce excessive purchasing behavior.

1.4 Conclusion

The fast-fashion textile industry operates as a highly complex, interconnected global system involving raw material producers, manufacturers, retail brands, logistics providers, recycling facilities, governments, and consumers. Applying systems thinking to this sector reveals that severe sustainability problems—such as environmental pollution, massive textile waste, and labor exploitation—are not isolated incidents, but rather direct systemic consequences of a linear business model entirely focused on speed, sheer volume, and artificially low costs. Because these actors are fundamentally linked, a disruption or policy change in one part of the chain inevitably impacts the entire system (Fontys University of Applied Sciences, 2026). Therefore, these systemic issues cannot be solved by a single actor acting alone.

However, as mapped throughout this chapter, the necessary transition toward a circular economy is not merely an environmental obligation; it is a major B2B strategic opportunity. While the current linear system faces impending regulatory crackdowns and resource depletion, the shift to circularity creates lucrative avenues for sustainable innovation, cleaner production technologies, ethical supply chain partnerships, and entirely new circular business models (Government of the Netherlands, 2024).

By understanding these interconnected causes, consequences, and stakeholder dynamics, companies can identify critical intervention points (Fontys University of Applied Sciences, 2026). Ultimately, this foundational problem analysis provides the necessary strategic groundwork for creating detailed system maps in the upcoming chapters, enabling the project team to effectively navigate and intervene in the B2B textile market.

Chapter 2: Case Study – Problem Mapping and Causal Loop Diagram

2.1 Introduction: The Iceberg Model in Systems Thinking

Building on the foundational problem mapping of Chapter 1, this chapter applies the systems thinking method more deeply to the textile industry through two analytical tools: the Iceberg Model and the Causal Loop Diagram (CLD). Where design thinking focuses on solving visible problems, systems thinking demands that we examine what lies beneath the surface the patterns, structures, and mental models that generate the events we observe (Senge, 1990). This distinction is critical: addressing only the visible symptoms of fast fashion without understanding the underlying system dynamics will, at best, produce temporary relief. True systemic change requires intervening at the level of structures and mental models.

This chapter presents four distinct Iceberg analyses Fast Fashion Overproduction, Factory Worker Exploitation, Water Pollution from Textile Dyeing, and the Rise of Sustainable Fashion followed by a professional Causal Loop Diagram that maps the key feedback loops driving the system. An important analytical concept applied throughout is the Jevons Paradox: the counterintuitive finding that technological efficiency gains often lead to increased rather than decreased consumption, because lower costs stimulate higher demand (Alcott, 2005). This paradox is particularly relevant in the textile industry, where production innovations repeatedly enable more output rather than less environmental impact.

2.2 The Iceberg Model: Four Analyses

The Iceberg Model is a core systems thinking tool that structures analysis across four layers: (1) Events what is immediately visible; (2) Patterns and Trends what has been happening over time; (3) Underlying Structures the rules, incentives, and systems producing those patterns; and (4) Mental Models the assumptions, beliefs, and worldviews that perpetuate those structures (Meadows, 2008). The four analyses below were each developed from the research conducted in Chapter 1, with each team member contributing their causal analysis as a starting point.

The visual overview of all four Iceberg analyses is presented below:

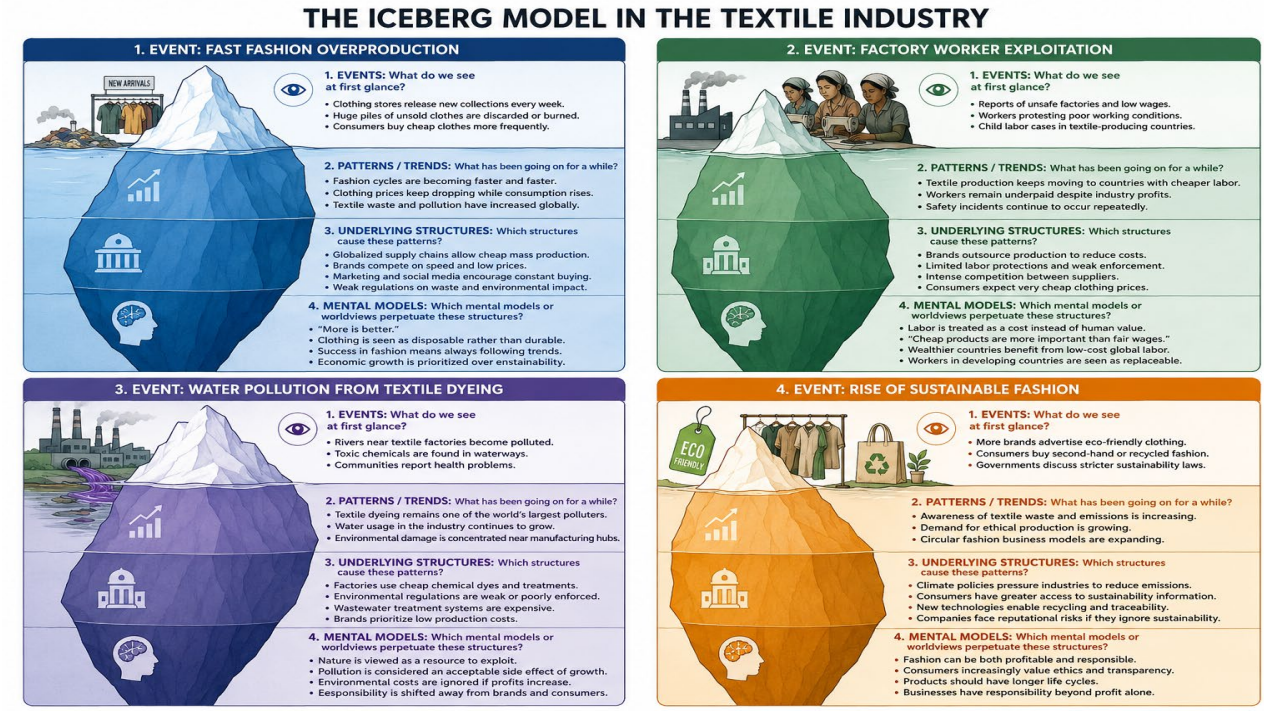


Figure 1. The Iceberg Model applied to four dimensions of the textile industry (Project 4 Team, 2026).

2.2.1 Iceberg Analysis 1: Fast Fashion Overproduction

Events: At the surface level, clothing stores release new collections weekly, resulting in enormous piles of unsold garments that are discarded or incinerated. Consumers purchase cheap apparel at unprecedented rates: between 2000 and 2014, global clothing production doubled, yet the number of times a garment is worn decreased by 36% (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2017).

Patterns and trends: For decades, fashion cycles have accelerated while retail prices have dropped continuously, fueling a global increase in textile waste. The industry now generates approximately 92 million tons of textile waste annually (Chen et al., 2021). Critically, the Jevons Paradox is visible here: each efficiency improvement in production cheaper synthetic fibers, faster logistics, automated cutting has historically been used to produce more garments at lower prices, rather than fewer garments more sustainably (Alcott, 2005).

Underlying structures: These patterns are driven by globalized supply chains optimized purely for speed and cost, brands competing on volume rather than value, algorithmically-targeted marketing designed to trigger constant repurchasing, and weak or absent regulations governing waste disposal and overproduction. The lack of Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR)

frameworks means brands bear no financial consequences for the end-of-life impact of their products (Jones & Leonas, 2023).

Mental models: The system is perpetuated by the dominant worldview that "more is better," that clothing is inherently disposable, and that economic growth justifies environmental costs. Consumer identity is increasingly tied to purchasing new items rather than maintaining existing ones (Alves et al., 2021). Until this mental model shifts from clothing as a product to clothing as a resource to be circulated structural interventions will face constant cultural resistance.

2.2.2 Iceberg Analysis 2: Factory Worker Exploitation

Events: Immediate reports of unsafe factories, poverty wages, child labour cases, and workers protesting dangerous conditions are regularly documented in textile-producing countries. The 2013 Rana Plaza collapse in Bangladesh which killed 1,134 garment workers remains the most visible example of how cost minimization at scale produces fatal outcomes (International Labour Organization, 2016).

Patterns and trends: Production consistently relocates to whichever country currently offers the cheapest labour, keeping workers perpetually underpaid despite massive industry profits. In Bangladesh, the minimum wage is approximately €80 per month against a living wage of €368 (Clean Clothes Campaign, 2024). Safety incidents recur predictably whenever cost pressure overrides safety investment (Bildirici et al., 2024).

Underlying structures: Brands systematically outsource production to reduce costs within a global structure of minimal labour protections and fierce competition between suppliers. Tier 2 and Tier 3 subcontractors often invisible to the final brand absorb the most extreme cost pressures. The fragmented nature of supply chains creates deliberate opacity that allows brands to deny accountability for conditions they effectively cause (Bick et al., 2018).

Mental models: This exploitation is rooted in the treatment of labour as a cost to minimize rather than as human value to protect. The mental model underpinning consumer behaviour that cheap products are a right, regardless of how they are produced enables this system to persist. Geographic and cultural distance between consumers in wealthy countries and workers in the Global South creates a moral abstraction that sustains the status quo (Bildirici et al., 2024).

2.2.3 Iceberg Analysis 3: Water Pollution from Textile Dyeing

Events: Rivers near textile manufacturing hubs in Bangladesh, India, and China run visibly discolored from toxic chemical dyes. Local communities report elevated rates of skin disease, respiratory illness, and contaminated drinking water. Textile dyeing and finishing account for up to 20% of global industrial water pollution (UNEP, 2018).

Patterns and trends: Textile dyeing has remained among the world's largest sources of water pollution for decades, with water consumption by the industry growing in absolute terms despite awareness campaigns. The industry consumes approximately 93 billion cubic meters of water

annually (Bildirici et al., 2024). As production volumes increase, so does the aggregate environmental damage, even when individual facilities improve their processes a direct manifestation of the Jevons Paradox at industry scale (Alcott, 2005).

Underlying structures: Factories rely on cheap synthetic chemical dyes because wastewater treatment infrastructure is expensive and environmental enforcement is weak in major production countries. Brands prioritize low unit costs over environmental compliance when selecting suppliers, effectively subsidizing pollution through their purchasing decisions. The absence of mandatory environmental due diligence in supply contracts creates no financial incentive for improvement (Saha et al., 2021).

Mental models: This pattern reflects a deep-seated worldview in which nature is a resource freely available for industrial exploitation and pollution is an acceptable, even inevitable, side effect of economic progress. Responsibility is systematically shifted from brands to factories, from factories to governments, and from governments to consumers creating a diffusion of accountability that prevents coordinated action (Saha et al., 2021).

2.2.4 Iceberg Analysis 4: The Rise of Sustainable Fashion

Events: A visible counter-movement is emerging: consumers are increasingly buying second-hand through platforms like Vinted and Depop; brands are launching "conscious collections"; and governments, particularly within the EU, are enacting stricter sustainability legislation including the EU Textile Strategy (2022) and forthcoming Extended Producer Responsibility frameworks (European Commission, 2024).

Patterns and trends: Consumer awareness of the environmental cost of fashion is measurably increasing. The global secondhand clothing market is projected to reach USD 350 billion by 2027, growing three times faster than the overall apparel market (Reinhart, 2023). Circular business models rental, repair, resale are expanding from niche propositions to mainstream commercial strategies. However, the Jevons Paradox again poses a risk: growing demand for "sustainable fashion" may simply add another consumption layer on top of existing fast fashion rather than replacing it (Alcott, 2005).

Underlying structures: New EU climate policies create regulatory pressure on brands to reduce emissions and improve transparency. Technologies such as blockchain-based Digital Product Passports make supply chain traceability commercially viable, enabling consumers to make genuinely informed choices. ESG investor pressure and sustainability reporting obligations are also shifting the financial incentives that govern corporate decision-making (Alves et al., 2021; Seidu et al., 2023).

Mental models: A meaningful shift in mental models is underway: fashion is increasingly being reconceived as a service or shared resource rather than a privately owned disposable product. Businesses are recognising that profitability and responsibility are compatible rather than contradictory goals. The belief that "products should have long life cycles" is slowly displacing

the disposability mindset but only systemic structural change can make this shift durable rather than cosmetic (Seidu et al., 2023).

2.3 Causal Loop Diagram: System Map of the Textile Industry

The Causal Loop Diagram (CLD) below maps the key variables and feedback relationships identified through the iceberg analyses. Each arrow indicates a causal relationship: a (+) sign means that an increase in the source variable leads to an increase in the target variable, while a (−) sign means the opposite. Two types of feedback loops are identified: Reinforcing loops (R), which amplify change in one direction and can drive either virtuous cycles or vicious cycles; and Balancing loops (B), which counteract change and create stabilizing or self-correcting dynamics (Meadows, 2008).

The diagram identifies two primary loops. The first is **R1 the Overconsumption Reinforcing Loop**: low production costs drive low clothing prices, which increases consumer purchases, which expands mass production, which drives further cost reduction a self-amplifying vicious cycle. The second is **B1 the Reputational Balancing Loop**: worker exploitation generates negative public awareness, which damages brand reputation, which creates pressure to reduce costs, which paradoxically drives further exploitation unless structural change intervenes. A third emerging loop is **R2 the Ethical Demand Reinforcing Loop**: consumer awareness drives ethical demand, which stimulates sustainable production, which reduces overconsumption over time. This loop represents the systemic leverage point where B2B marketing and strategic consulting can most effectively intervene.

Initial version of the Causal Loop Diagram (hand-drawn, class session):

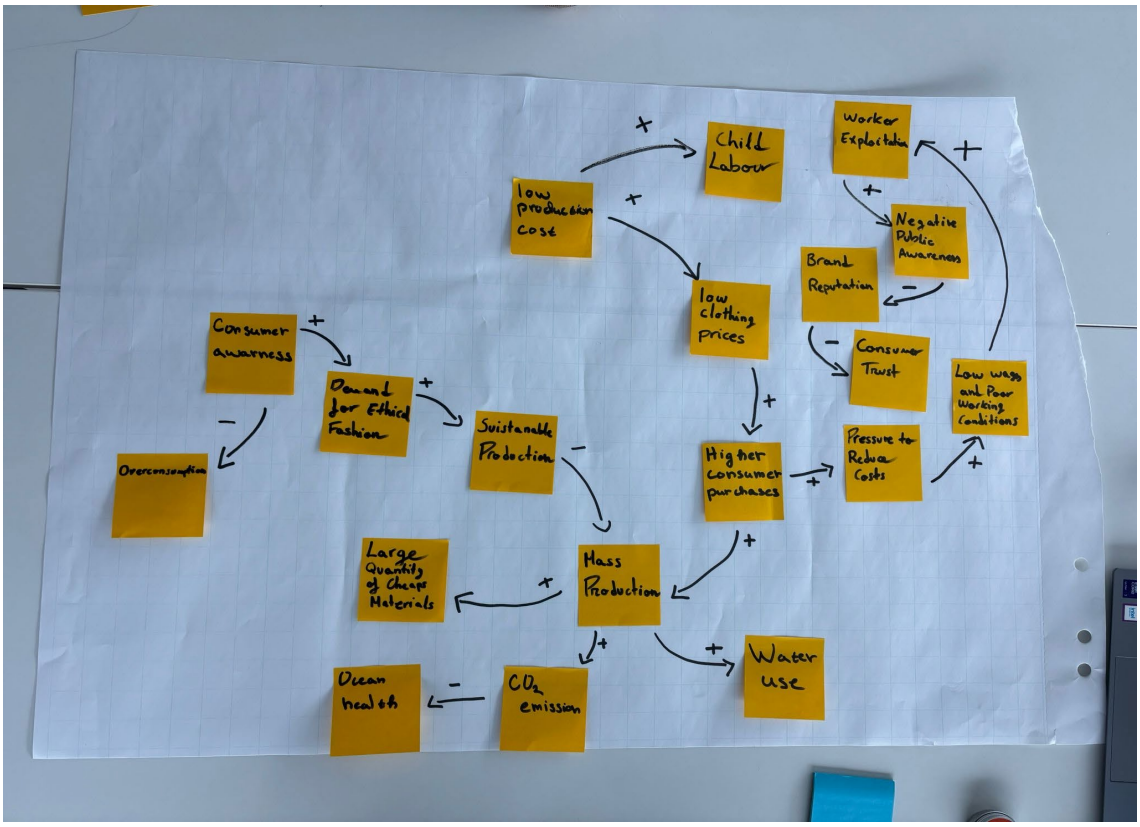
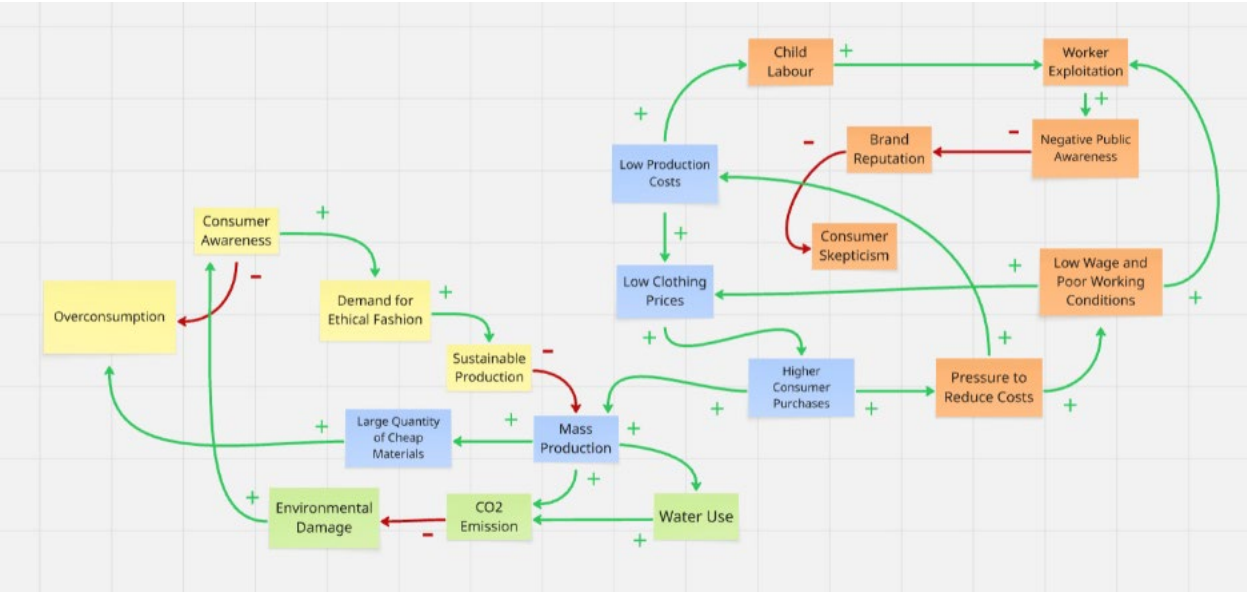


Figure 2. Initial hand-drawn Causal Loop Diagram created during class session (Project 4 Team, 2026).

Polished Version of Loop Diagram:



2.4 Causal Loop Diagram: Relationship Table and B2B Actor Mapping

The table below provides a structured breakdown of each causal relationship identified in the system map, specifying the direction of influence (+/−) and the specific B2B industry actors that operate within each link. This actor mapping is a critical step toward identifying which companies are strategic leverage points and therefore suitable candidates for the strategic consulting question developed in later chapters.

Relationship Path	Influence	Key B2B Industry Actors
Consumer Awareness → Overconsumption	−	Marketing & PR Agencies (drive desire cycles); E-commerce Platforms (enable one-click purchasing)
Consumer Awareness → Ethical Demand	+	NGOs & Certifying Bodies (define ethical standards); B Corp Consultancies (advise on social impact)
Ethical Demand → Sustainable Production	+	Textile Research Institutes (innovate low-impact fibres); Chemical Suppliers (develop non-toxic dyes); Sustainable Fabric Mills
Sustainable Production → Mass Production	−	Sustainable Fabric Mills (often operate at smaller scales, conflicting with high-volume fast fashion models)
Mass Production → CO_2 / Water Use / Cheap Materials	+	Logistics & Freight Forwarders; Energy Providers (power large-scale mills); Industrial Laundries (high water use); Chemical Dye Suppliers
Mass Production → Higher Consumer Purchases	+	Wholesale Distributors (move bulk inventory to retail); Fast-Fashion Retailers (rely on high turnover); E-commerce Platforms
Pressure to Reduce Costs → Low Wages / Worker Exploitation	+	Tier 2 & Tier 3 Subcontractors (absorb lowest-margin orders); Sourcing Agents (negotiate lowest possible prices)
Worker Exploitation → Negative Public Awareness	+	Investigative NGOs & Watchdogs (monitor supply chain ethics); ESG Rating Agencies (inform investors of labour risks)

Negative Public Awareness → Brand Reputation	−	Crisis Management Firms (hired to repair image); Impact Marketing Agencies (help brands pivot to green messaging)
Low Production Cost → Child Labour / Low Clothing Prices	+	Unregulated Manufacturers (operate in weak enforcement regions); Discount Importers (bring low-cost goods into domestic markets)

Table 1. Causal Loop Diagram relationship table with B2B actor mapping (Project 4 Team, 2026).

2.5 Target Company List

Based on the system map developed above, the following companies have been identified as strategic leverage points within the textile system. Each company sits at a critical node in the causal loop structure making them suitable candidates for future strategic consulting engagement. Selection criteria include: position within a key feedback loop, exposure to sustainability regulation, and relevance to the B2B textile market.

Manufacturers and Fabric Innovators

TenCate Protective Fabrics (Netherlands): A large-scale Dutch manufacturer that must balance high-volume mass production with growing sustainable production requirements for technical safety wear. Positioned directly in the Mass Production and Sustainable Production nodes of the CLD, making it a relevant target for a strategic question around circular material innovation.

Lenzing Group (Austria/Global): Producers of TENCEL™ lyocell and modal fibres, which are positioned in the Sustainable Production and Ethical Materials nodes. Lenzing actively drives the R2 Ethical Demand loop and is a prime example of a B2B supplier that could be approached to understand how sustainable fibre innovation translates into commercial strategy.

Importers and Global Sourcing Agents

Li & Fung (Global): One of the world's largest supply chain orchestrators, sitting directly in the Pressure to Reduce Costs and Mass Production loops. As a central intermediary between brands and manufacturers, Li & Fung has enormous structural influence over labour standards and sustainability practices across Tier 2 and Tier 3 suppliers.

PVH Corp (European HQ: Amsterdam): Owners of Calvin Klein and Tommy Hilfiger, PVH must actively manage Brand Reputation and Consumer Trust nodes while navigating EU EPR regulations. Their Amsterdam presence makes them directly accessible for outreach.

Retailers and Distributors

MUD Jeans (Netherlands): A circular economy leader operating a "Lease a Jeans" model, explicitly designed to break the Overconsumption and Mass Production loops. MUD Jeans

demonstrates the R2 Ethical Demand loop in commercial practice and would be an ideal company for a strategic question around scaling circular B2C models into B2B supply chain partnerships.

Zeeman (Netherlands): A discount retailer deeply embedded in the Low Clothing Prices and Higher Consumer Purchases nodes. Zeeman currently faces the strategic challenge of integrating sustainable production without losing its core value proposition making it a relevant and realistic consulting target.

Patagonia (European HQ: Amsterdam): Primarily drives Consumer Awareness and Ethical Demand nodes while actively resisting the Overconsumption loop through its "Don't Buy This Jacket" campaigns and worn-wear repair programmes. A benchmark for how brand positioning can leverage the R2 loop to create competitive differentiation through sustainability.

2.6 Conclusion

The four iceberg analyses developed in this chapter reveal that the visible crises of fast fashion waste mountains, polluted rivers, exploited workers are not isolated failures but the predictable outputs of a system governed by deeply embedded structures and mental models. No single actor, technology, or regulation can resolve these issues in isolation; only interventions that target the underlying feedback loops can produce durable systemic change.

The Causal Loop Diagram demonstrates that the most powerful leverage point for B2B marketing intervention lies in reinforcing the R2 Ethical Demand loop: by building commercial relationships with companies operating at the intersection of consumer awareness, sustainable production, and ethical supply chain management, a strategic consultant can simultaneously create business value and systemic positive change. The target companies identified in Section 2.5 represent the first step in this strategic selection process, which will be refined in the following chapters through company-specific assumption mapping and DMU analysis.

Chapter 3: Choose Your Own Chain – Health and Sports Nutrition Industry

Building upon the foundational systems thinking principles applied to the textile industry in previous chapters, this section shifts focus to a self-selected chain. To prepare for the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project, the Health and Sports Nutrition industry has been chosen as the primary area of analysis. This chapter will explore the systemic challenges within this sector, identifying the root causes and consequences of a specific industry-wide problem. By applying analytical frameworks such as the Iceberg Model and a Causal Loop Diagram, this chapter aims to map the complex interdependencies of the health and sports nutrition chain and uncover strategic intervention points for future B2B marketing solutions.

3.1 Chain Selection and Problem Definition

3.1.1 Selected Chain

The health and sports nutrition supply chain was selected for this chapter, with a specific focus on functional food brands producing protein supplements, meal replacements, and dietary nutrition products. Fueled by the rising adoption of fitness regimes and an increasing awareness of health and wellness, the sports nutrition sector has experienced explosive global market growth in recent years (Grand View Research, 2023). This chain sits within the broader food industry and presents a rich set of systemic sustainability challenges that are directly relevant to the scope and goals of B2B strategic consulting.

3.1.2 Problem Definition

The core systemic problem within the health and sports nutrition industry is a documented paradox: the sector aggressively markets its products to consumers under the premise of "health, wellness, and sustainability," yet its foundational supply chain mechanics are highly carbon-intensive and ecologically damaging.

This problem manifests across three scientifically and legally documented areas:

1. **High-Carbon Ingredient Sourcing:** The health and sports nutrition industry relies heavily on dairy-derived whey protein. Because dairy production is consistently scientifically ranked as one of the most carbon- and water-intensive agricultural systems globally (Poore & Nemecek, 2018), the baseline formulation of most traditional sports nutrition products carries a massive inherent greenhouse gas footprint.

2. **Non-Circular Packaging:** To maximize shelf life, the sector is heavily dependent on composite, single-use plastic tubs and multi-layer foil pouches. As highlighted by the Ellen MacArthur Foundation (2022) and UNEP (2021), composite and flexible packaging materials are notoriously difficult to recycle within standard municipal systems, significantly contributing to global landfill accumulation and marine plastic pollution
3. **Unverified Green Marketing (Greenwashing):** To capture eco-conscious consumers, many nutrition brands utilize vague sustainability claims (e.g., "eco-friendly" or "clean"). The proliferation of these unsubstantiated claims has distorted the market to the point that the European Commission (2023) introduced the Green Claims Directive to legally mandate scientific verification and penalize corporate greenwashing.

Ultimately, this creates a growing gap between brand promises and actual environmental impact. To fully analyze this complex system, this report examines the interconnected mechanics between upstream production (formulation and packaging) and downstream retail dynamics (gatekeepers to the end-consumer).

3.2 Causes and Consequences

To effectively intervene in the health and sports nutrition sector, it is essential to map the root drivers of inefficiency and their downstream effects. Because this B2B chain is highly complex, these systemic causes and consequences encompass both upstream production dynamics and downstream retail pressures.

3.2.1 Perspective 1: Production & Brand Dynamics (Manar Alsadi)

At the upstream level, the physical formulation, packaging, and marketing strategies of the nutrition brands themselves lock severe environmental damage into the supply chain.

5 Systematic Causes:

1. **High Demand for Animal-Based Protein:** Whey protein is derived from dairy, one of the most carbon- and water-intensive food production systems globally. Consumer demand for protein products continues to rise, directly increasing pressure on dairy supply chains (Poore & Nemecek, 2018).
2. **Dominant Use of Single-Use Plastic Packaging:** Sports nutrition products are predominantly packaged in multi-layered composite materials. Because there is currently no industry-wide circular system or infrastructure capable of recycling these specific composites at scale (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2022), this locks the brand into a linear waste model.
3. **Lack of Supply Chain Transparency:** The European Commission (2022) explicitly highlights that complex, multi-tier global value chains make it inherently difficult to track

adverse environmental and social impacts. For sports nutrition brands, this means sourcing ingredients often involves opaque networks where verifying the exact production conditions of raw materials is nearly impossible without strict tracing protocols.

4. **Regulatory Gap Enabling Greenwashing:** Until recently, EU legislation did not require companies to substantiate environmental marketing claims with scientific evidence, allowing brands to use terms like "eco-friendly" without proof (European Commission, 2023).
5. **Growth of Fitness Culture Driving Overconsumption:** The global sports nutrition market has grown significantly, fuelled by influencer marketing. This creates pressure to produce more, faster, and cheaper—often at the expense of sustainability standards (Grand View Research, 2023).

5 Systemic Consequences:

1. **Accumulation of Plastic Waste:** The dominance of single-use plastic packaging means many composite types cannot be processed by standard municipal recycling systems, ultimately ending up in landfills or incineration (UNEP, 2021).
2. **High Greenhouse Gas Emissions:** Dairy-based protein production is responsible for significant greenhouse gas emissions, making it harder for nutrition brands to achieve genuine carbon neutrality claims (Poore & Nemecek, 2018).
3. **Consumer Distrust and Brand Credibility Damage:** According to the Edelman Trust Barometer (2023), global consumers increasingly distrust corporate sustainability claims and rely on media and NGOs to expose greenwashing. For the sports nutrition sector, this poses a severe reputational risk, as brands built specifically on promises of 'health' and 'quality' have the furthest to fall when their claims are disproven.
4. **Regulatory and Legal Risk:** The EU Green Claims Directive and CSRD will require companies to verify claims. Brands that cannot substantiate their sustainability positioning face fines, forced rebranding, and loss of market access (European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2022).
5. **Competitive Disadvantage:** Major industry players are increasingly investing in sustainable sourcing and circular packaging to meet new B2B demands (DSM-Firmenich, 2023). Consequently, smaller brands that do not keep pace risk losing B2B clients who now require verified sustainability credentials.

3.2.2 Perspective 2: Retail & Distribution Dynamics (Amira Kartika Rochman)

5 Systemic Causes:

1. **Strict Shelf-Life Requirements:** To minimize commercial spoilage, sports nutrition retailers demand long, stable shelf lives, which forces upstream reliance on multi-layered plastic packaging. Extreme cost pressures in the packaging industry drive retailers to rely on cheap, flexible, and single-use plastics to maintain their operational margins (McKinsey & Company, 2026).
2. **Lack of B2B Verification Tools:** There is a systemic lack of transparency and data regarding environmental impacts across global corporate value chains (European Commission, 2022). At the retail level, this means B2B buyers frequently lack the verifiable data required to substantiate a brand's 'eco-friendly' claims, leading them to unknowingly stock greenwashed products on their physical shelves.
3. **Consumer Price Sensitivity:** While consumer interest in sustainability is rising, purchasing behavior shows that consumers consistently prioritize personal health benefits over environmental impact, making them highly reluctant to pay a "green premium" (Hazley & Kearney, 2024). This price sensitivity forces mass-market retail buyers to prioritize cheaper, mass-produced products over sustainable alternatives to protect their tight profit margins.
4. **Demand for Aesthetic Shelf Presence:** Supermarkets demand eye-catching packaging to dominate physical shelf space. This leads to the industry-wide practice of "slack fill" (selling half-empty tubs), directly contradicting the growing industry need for cost discipline and packaging volume reduction (McKinsey & Company, 2026).
5. **Fragmented Reverse Logistics:** Despite pressure to shift toward reusable packaging, the retail sector broadly lacks the standardized infrastructure needed for collection, and the transaction costs for returning packaging remain a significant expense (Mission Reuse, 2023). In the sports nutrition context, retailers currently have no standardized reverse logistics system to collect empty protein tubs from consumers, blocking true circularity.

5 Systemic Consequences:

1. **Inheriting Massive Scope 3 Emissions:** Under the EU CSRD, companies are mandated to report on Scope 3 indirect greenhouse gas emissions, which for food companies can account for up to 96% of their total emissions profile (Sustainalytics, 2026). For large retailers, this means continuing to stock carbon-intensive dairy whey directly inflates their own corporate emissions ledger, creating a massive environmental liability.
2. **Brand Trust Erosion:** Greenwashing primarily impacts a business's hard-earned reputation, adversely affects market integrity, and rapidly erodes consumer trust (Deloitte, n.d.). In the localized context of sports nutrition, this means that prominent gyms or supermarkets caught stocking falsely advertised supplements will likely face secondary "guilt by association," damaging their own retail reputation.

3. **Incoming Legal Penalties:** The EU Green Claims Directive establishes strict rules against unverified environmental claims (European Commission, 2023), and regulatory attention on greenwashing can result in significant financial penalties (Deloitte, n.d.). Retailers could soon face severe legal liability for actively promoting falsely advertised products on their shelves.
4. **High Waste Disposal Costs:** The commercial retail sector bears a massive economic burden for managing plastic solid waste, as the transaction and logistics costs for handling packaging are highly complex and expensive (Mission Reuse, 2023). Gym chains that heavily sell single-use sports nutrition products generate massive amounts of plastic waste on-site, forcing the retailer to directly absorb heavy commercial waste disposal fees.
5. **Loss of Eco-Conscious Market Share:** Because the willingness to pay a premium is strongly limited when consumers prioritize physical performance over the planet (Hazley & Kearney, 2024), traditional retailers that fail to curate genuinely sustainable product lines risk losing their competitive edge and eco-conscious consumer base to specialized eco-retailers.

3.3 System Mapping: The Iceberg Model

To understand why the health and sports nutrition industry continues to generate massive environmental damage despite marketing itself as a "wellness" sector, the Iceberg Model is applied to the supply chain as a whole. This model looks beneath the surface-level events to expose the hidden structural mechanics and B2B mental models driving the behavior of the entire system.

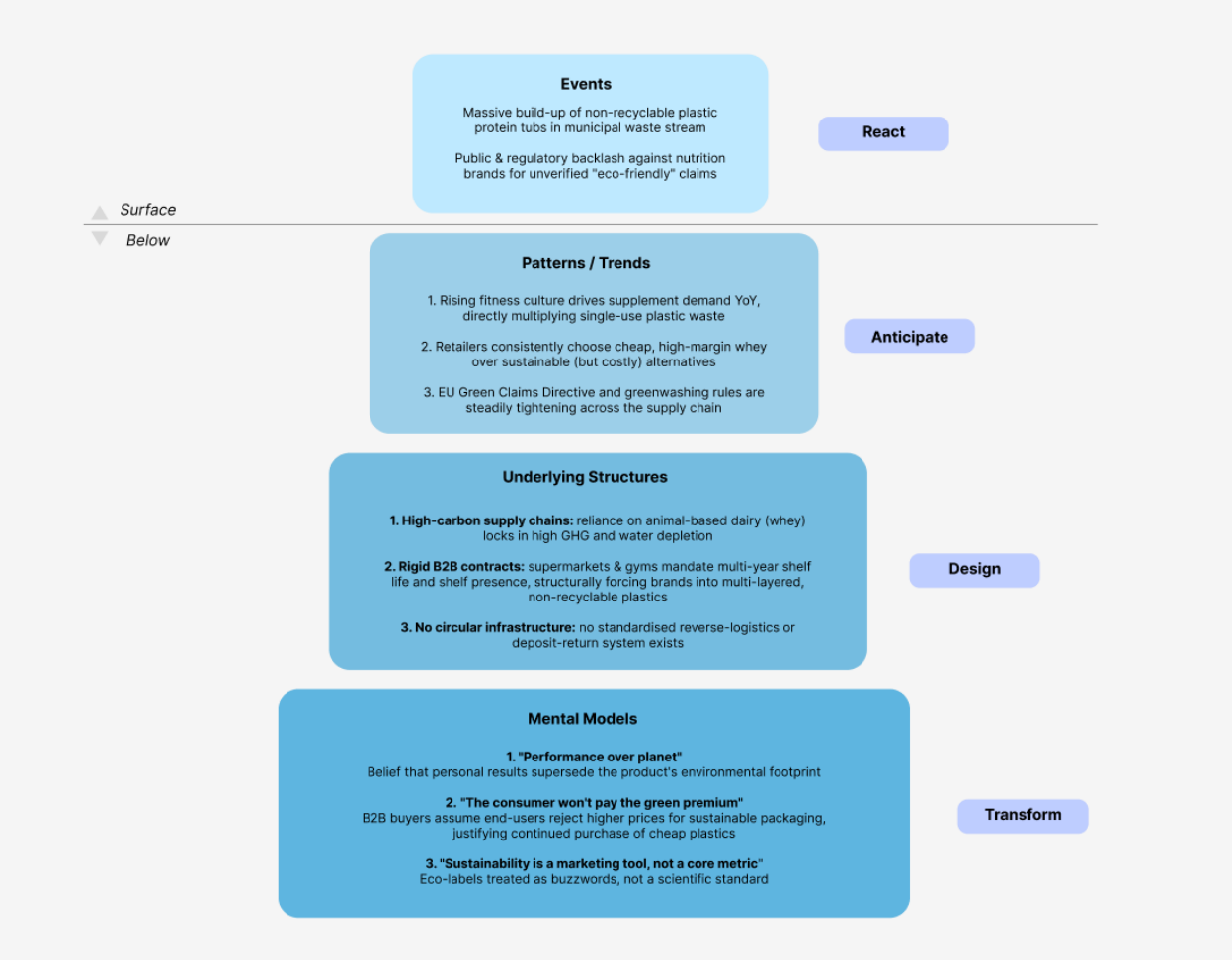


Figure 1: Iceberg Model: Health & Sports Nutrition Industry

Level	Question	Content
Events (React)	What just happened?	The industry is currently facing a dual crisis at the surface level: a massive accumulation of non-recyclable plastic protein tubs in municipal waste streams, and sudden public/regulatory

		backlash against nutrition brands for unverified "eco-friendly" marketing claims.
Patterns / Trends (Anticipate)	What has been happening over time?	1. **Rising Demand vs. Linear Production:** Driven by social media fitness culture, consumer demand for protein supplements grows year over year, directly increasing the volume of single-use plastics produced and discarded. 2. **Retailer Pushback on Price:** Despite corporate climate pledges, retail buyers consistently pass over sustainable (but expensive) nutrition products in favor of stocking cheaper, high-margin, mass-produced whey products. 3. **Regulatory Squeeze:** EU sustainability and greenwashing regulations (such as the Green Claims Directive) are steadily tightening, increasing legal pressure on the entire supply chain.
Structures (Design)	What rules & relationships influence patterns?	1. **High-Carbon Supply Chains:** The foundational reliance on the animal-based dairy chain (whey protein) structurally locks high greenhouse gas emissions and water depletion into the product formulation. 2. **Rigid B2B Retail Contracts:** Supermarkets and gyms enforce uncompromising procurement rules requiring multi-year shelf stability and eye-catching "shelf presence" (slack fill), which structurally forces brands to use multi-layered, non-recyclable plastics.

		3. **Lack of Circular Infrastructure:** There is no standardized B2B reverse logistics system (such as a deposit return scheme) between consumers, retailers, and brands to collect, sanitize, and reuse empty tubs.
Mental Models (Transform)	What beliefs keep the system in place?	4. **"Performance Over Planet":** The deeply ingrained industry and consumer belief that personal physical results (e.g., maximizing protein yield per gram) supersede the environmental footprint of the ingredients. 5. **"The Consumer Won't Pay the Green Premium":** The prevailing assumption among B2B buyers that end-consumers will not accept higher prices for sustainable packaging, justifying the continued purchase of cheap plastics to protect retail profit margins. 6. **"Sustainability is a Marketing Tool, Not a Core Metric":** The historical industry belief that "eco-friendly" is just a buzzword to print on a label to drive sales, rather than a scientific standard that requires rigorous supply chain verification.

3.4 System Map: Causal Loop Diagram

While the Iceberg Model uncovers the hidden structures and mental models of the health and sports nutrition sector, a Causal Loop Diagram (CLD) is required to visualize how these elements interact dynamically. The system map below illustrates the feedback loops connecting upstream production (brands and manufacturers) with downstream market forces (retailers, regulations, and consumer behavior). By mapping these interconnected variables, it becomes clear how actions in one part of the supply chain trigger cascading environmental and economic effects throughout the entire system.

In the diagram below, arrows indicate causal direction: a (+) indicates a positive relationship (as one variable increases, the other increases), while a (−) indicates a negative relationship (as one variable increases, the other decreases).

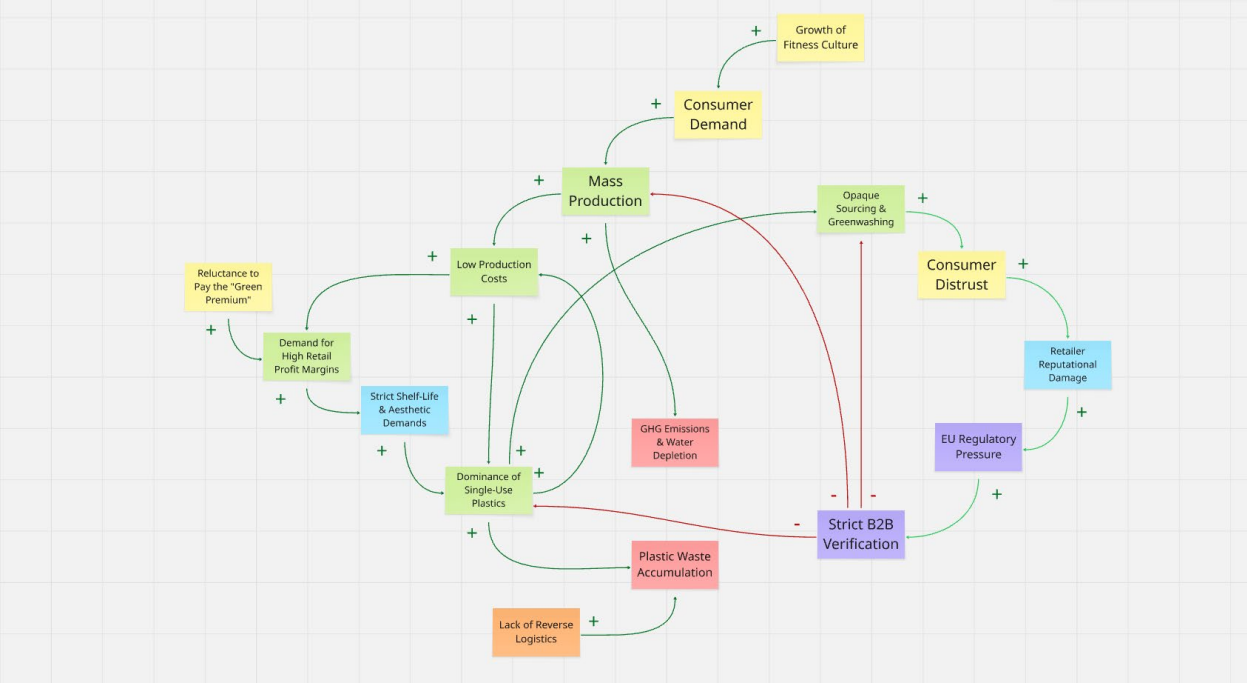


Figure 2: Causal Loop Diagram: Health & Sports Nutrition Industry

3.4.1 System Map Explanation

1. The Economic & Overconsumption Trap (Reinforcing)

The system begins with psychological and market drivers: **Influencer Fitness Culture** (+) accelerates overall **Demand for Protein Supplements**. To meet this demand profitably, brands rely on the **Mass Production of Dairy/Whey** (+), which ensures **Low Production Costs** (+). Because retail buyers operate in a highly competitive market, these low upstream costs directly fuel the **Demand for High Retail Profit Margins** (+). This dynamic is further entrenched by the consumer's **Reluctance to Pay the "Green Premium"** (+), which signals to retailers that

protecting profit margins is more commercially viable than sourcing expensive, sustainable alternatives.

2. The Plastic & Waste Cascade (Reinforcing) The economic trap directly dictates the physical packaging of the product. To protect their high margins and maximize sales, retailers enforce **Strict Shelf-Life & Aesthetic Demands** (+) (such as oversized "slack-fill" packaging). This downstream demand, combined with upstream low costs, solidifies the industry's **Dominance of Single-Use Plastics** (+). Because plastic is cheap, it creates a self-reinforcing cycle back to **Low Production Costs** (+). Ultimately, this mass production and plastic dominance fracture into severe environmental consequences: massive **GHG Emissions & Water Depletion** (+) and rapid **Plastic Waste Accumulation** (+), the latter of which is exacerbated by a complete **Lack of Reverse Logistics** (+) between retailers and consumers.

3. The Trust Crisis & Corrective "Brakes" (Balancing)

The system's corrective mechanism is driven by reputation and legislation. To obscure their environmental footprint, brands engage in **Opaque Sourcing & Greenwashing** (+). However, as public awareness grows, this triggers severe **Consumer Skepticism & Distrust** (+), which travels downstream to cause **Retailer Reputational Damage ("Guilt by Association")** (+).

This reputational damage and resulting **EU Regulatory Pressure** (+) force the ultimate systemic correction. To survive legal scrutiny, downstream buyers must enforce **Strict B2B Procurement & Verification Rules**. This gatekeeper intervention acts as the critical "brake" on the system, sending powerful negative (−) pressures back up the supply chain to actively reduce Greenwashing, decrease the Dominance of Single-Use Plastics, and force a pivot away from the Mass Production of high-carbon Dairy.

3.5 Challenges and Opportunities

The transition from a linear "take-make-dispose" model to a circular economy presents distinct challenges and strategic opportunities for every stakeholder. To successfully intervene in the health and sports nutrition system as a B2B marketer or strategic consultant, it is essential to map the varying pressures and incentives driving the individual actors within the supply chain.

Because intervening successfully requires understanding the distinct pressures at both ends of the B2B relationship, our team has chosen to outline the specific challenges and opportunities for two critical business types within this system: the Upstream Manufacturer and the Downstream Retailer.

3.5.1 Individual Analysis: Manar Alsadi (Focus: Upstream Manufacturer)

CHALLENGES	OPPORTUNITIES
Regulatory Scrutiny Difficulty substantiating sustainability claims under EU Green Claims Directive.	**First-Mover Advantage** First-mover advantage in certified sustainable packaging in the Dutch sports nutrition market.
Financial Barriers High cost of switching from plastic to certified sustainable packaging at small-brand scale.	**B2B Expansion** Growing B2B demand from gyms, corporate wellness programs, and healthcare providers seeking credible sustainable nutrition partners.
Opaque Sourcing Limited leverage over multi-tier ingredient supply chains to verify environmental conditions.	**Ingredient Pivot** Plant-based protein shifts (pea, rice, hemp) reduce dependency on high-carbon dairy supply chains.
Consumer Skepticism Growing consumer skepticism towards health nutrition brand marketing.	**Digital Transparency** Digital-first business model enables direct consumer education and transparent sustainability storytelling.
Corporate Competition Competitive pressure from large players with larger sustainability R&D budgets.	**Leveling the Playing Field** EU policy pressure creating level playing field brands that invest early will be structurally ahead of competitors.

3.5.2 Individual Analysis: Amira Kartika Rochman (Focus: Downstream Retailer)

CHALLENGES	OPPORTUNITIES
"Guilt by Association" and Trust Erosion As consumer trust in health brands declines due to perceived greenwashing, retailers face severe secondary reputational risks. If a supermarket stocks brands that are later exposed for unverified claims, the retailer's own brand equity and social license to operate are damaged by association.	**Exercising B2B Gatekeeper Power** Retailers hold ultimate leverage over the supply chain. They can implement strict sustainable procurement standards, requiring upstream brands to prove their carbon footprint before granting them physical shelf space to proactively mitigate their own Scope 3 emissions.
Incoming Legal & Financial Risk Under the EU Green Claims Directive, it will become legally risky for retailers to promote products as "eco-friendly" on their shelves without scientific substantiation, which exposes the business to significant financial penalties.	**Closed-Loop Store Partnerships** Gym chains and specialty retailers have a unique physical opportunity to bypass the expensive reverse logistics of plastic waste. By installing bulk protein dispensers in-store, they can entirely eliminate the transaction costs of single-use packaging.
The Retail Margin Trap Transitioning shelf space to sustainably packaged brands threaten short-term B2B profit margins because many mass-market consumers refuse to pay the "green premium" at checkout	**Private Label Innovation** Large retailers can capitalize on the industry's greenwashing crisis by launching their own highly transparent, sustainably sourced "private label" nutrition lines, protecting their reputation and capturing consumer trust.
Commercial Waste Management Burden Gym chains (like Basic-Fit) that sell single-use sports nutrition products via vending machines generate massive amounts of plastic waste on-site. Managing this without standardized infrastructure results in significant transaction and operational expenses.	**Data-Driven Shelf Positioning** As Digital Product Passports become more common, retailers can use verified sustainability data to reorganize their shelves, giving premium placement to genuinely sustainable brands and justifying a green premium for segmented, eco-conscious customers.

Absorbing Scope 3 Emissions Under the incoming CSRD, large retailers are legally required to report their Scope 3 indirect greenhouse gas emissions. By stocking high-carbon dairy whey, retailers inherit a massive environmental reporting liability.	**Strategic Eco-Brand Exclusivity** Forward-thinking retailers can secure exclusive B2B distribution rights with first-mover sustainable brands (like Upfront). This allows the retailer to attract high-end, corporate wellness programs that demand verified sustainability without succumbing to intense packaging cost pressures.

3.6 Company Lists

The following companies can be connected to the nodes and relationships identified in the system map. The list is organized by the supply chain stage and includes the type of company, their country, and their role within the health nutrition system.

① Raw Material Suppliers Node: Fitness culture → production demand		
Company	**Country**	**Role in System**
FrieslandCampina	Netherlands	Major dairy cooperative; produces whey protein used in sports nutrition
Roquette	France	World's largest pea protein manufacturer; supplies plant-based protein
Tereos	France / NL	Sugar and starch producer; ingredient supplier to food & nutrition brands
Cosucra	Belgium	Produces pea protein and chicory fibre for nutrition brands

② Ingredient Processors & Certifiers Node: Supply chain transparency		
Company	**Country**	**Role in System**
DSM-Firmenich	Netherlands	Global nutrition ingredient company; produces vitamins, proteins & sustainable ingredient solutions
Cargill	Netherlands (EU HQ)	Processes and trades food ingredients including cocoa, oils & proteins
Kerry Group	Ireland / NL	Taste & nutrition ingredient supplier to food brands
Ingredion	Global / NL office	Specialty ingredient processor supplying food manufacturers

③ Health Nutrition Brands Node: Central problem (Upfront's tier)		
Company	**Country**	**Role in System**
Upfront (FOCUS)	Netherlands	Focus company; D2C health nutrition brand; protein powder & supplements
Body & Fit	Netherlands	Large Dutch sports nutrition brand & retailer; direct competitor
Foodspring	Germany / NL	Health nutrition brand with sustainability positioning; competitor
Bulk (formerly Bulk Powders)	UK / EU	Major European sports nutrition brand; operates in NL market
MyProtein	UK / EU	Largest European sports nutrition brand; benchmark for Upfront

Queal	Netherlands	Dutch meal replacement brand; similar sustainability challenges to Upfront

④ Packaging Manufacturers Node: Plastic packaging use & waste		
Company	**Country**	**Role in System**
Greiner Packaging	Austria / NL office	Produces plastic food & nutrition containers; active in NL market
Coveris	Europe / NL	Flexible packaging manufacturer; produces pouches used in nutrition products
Smurfit Kappa	Netherlands	Sustainable packaging solutions; paper-based alternative packaging
Sealed Air	Global / NL	Packaging materials company; active in food & nutrition packaging

⑤ Logistics & Distribution Node: Distribution channels & CO_2 emissions		
Company	**Country**	**Role in System**
PostNL	Netherlands	National parcel delivery; handles Upfront's D2C webshop fulfilment
DHL Supply Chain	Netherlands	B2B logistics & warehousing for food & nutrition brands
Bol.com (logistics)	Netherlands	E-commerce marketplace & logistics partner for nutrition brands
Picnic	Netherlands	Online grocery delivery with sustainability focus; potential B2B channel for Upfront

⑥ Retailers & B2B Clients Node: Distribution channels → consumer trust

Company	Country	Role in System
Basic-Fit	Netherlands	Largest gym chain in NL; major B2B buyer of nutrition products
Jumbo / Albert Heijn	Netherlands	Supermarket chains selling health nutrition products; potential retail partner
Ekoplaza	Netherlands	Organic & sustainable food retailer; relevant for Upfront's sustainability positioning
Holland & Barrett	NL / UK	Health food & supplement retailer; distribution channel in NL

⑦ Regulatory & Policy Bodies Node: EU regulation (balancing loop)

Organisation	Level	Role in System
European Commission	EU	Issues Green Claims Directive (2023) & CSRD forces brands to verify sustainability claims
NVWA (Nederlandse Voedsel- en Warenautoriteit)	Netherlands	Dutch food safety authority; enforces labelling and product claim regulations
ACM (Autoriteit Consument & Markt)	Netherlands	Dutch consumer authority; investigates and fines companies for greenwashing in marketing

⑧ Sustainability & Certification Bodies Node: Brand sustainability investment

Organisation	Country	Role in System
SGS Netherlands	Netherlands	Certification and testing for food quality and sustainability standards
Control Union	Netherlands	Dutch certification body for organic, fair trade and sustainability standards
B Lab Europe	Netherlands	Issues B Corp certification; relevant for brands like Upfront seeking credibility
Circle Economy	Netherlands	Amsterdam-based circular economy consultancy; advises brands on sustainability strategy

3.7 Chapter Conclusion

The health and sports nutrition industry sits at a critical intersection of explosive market growth and impending sustainability regulations. By mapping this supply chain, it becomes evident that the environmental footprint of the industry—driven by carbon-intensive dairy sourcing and single-use plastics—cannot be solved by a single actor. It is a systemic issue maintained by the "Growth Loop" of consumer demand and the "Trust Loop" of greenwashed marketing.

Moving forward into the strategic consulting phase, interventions must be tailored to specific supply chain actors. While nutrition brands must navigate the financial hurdles of verifying their green claims and sourcing eco-packaging, the ultimate leverage lies downstream. Retailers and B2B buyers have the power to structurally shift the market by enforcing strict, transparent procurement standards before products ever reach the physical shelf. Only by addressing both the upstream production pressures and the downstream gatekeeper rules can this B2B chain successfully transition to a circular, compliant model.

Chapter 4: Company Selection and Assumption Formulation

4.1 Introduction and Selection Rationale

Chapter 4 builds directly upon the systemic analysis developed in Chapter 3. Having mapped the structural challenges of the health and sports nutrition supply chain, this chapter transitions from analysis to strategic application. Three companies have been selected from the company list compiled in Chapter 3 one from each of three distinct but interconnected positions in the system map: a D2C brand (Upfront), a gym-chain B2B buyer (Basic-Fit), and a sustainable retailer (Ekoplaza). Together, these three companies represent the complete B2B transaction chain through which the sustainability problems identified in Chapter 3 must ultimately be resolved. For each company, five challenges and five opportunities are identified, each supported by desk research and APA citations. An individual assumption is then formulated per challenge and opportunity, yielding 10 per company and 30 in total.

4.2 Company 1: Upfront (Rotterdam, Netherlands)

Company Profile

Upfront was founded in 2020 and is headquartered in Rotterdam, Netherlands, where it operates as a funded D2C health nutrition brand (Tracxn, 2026). The brand is known for its commitment to transparency and quality in protein products, with a dedicated following built on honest labelling, sustainability storytelling, and direct consumer engagement (Wheree, 2025). Upfront's founding philosophy centres on developing products with all ingredients and nutritional information listed on the front of packaging food that consumers can understand which led to more transparent product development, more honest business practices, and ultimately better products (De Bonte Koe, 2024). Upfront sits at the central Brand/Manufacturer node of the Causal Loop Diagram developed in Chapter 3, making it the primary subject of this strategic consulting analysis.

Selection Rationale

Upfront was selected for three converging reasons. First, it is a Dutch D2C brand positioned at the exact node in the health and sports nutrition system map where the core problem the paradox between wellness marketing and unsustainable production is most acutely felt. Second, as identified in Chapter 3 (Section 3.5.1), Upfront represents a genuine first-mover sustainability opportunity in the Dutch market: a brand that has publicly committed to transparency and is structurally positioned to lead certified sustainable packaging adoption before larger competitors. Third, as a Rotterdam-based, digitally-native SME operating in a well-documented and regulated Dutch market, Upfront is a highly realistic and accessible Year 2 strategic consulting target.

Challenges

Challenge 1 Regulatory Compliance Burden Under EU Greenwashing Legislation (Sustainability-linked)

Upfront actively uses sustainability and transparency as core brand values. However, food and beverage brands must now substantiate all sustainability claims with evidence, including conducting lifecycle assessments, tracking environmental data through the supply chain, and ensuring third-party certifications are used accurately (FI Global Insights, 2025). Furthermore, Directive 2024/825 has introduced substantial amendments prohibiting unfounded generic claims and non-certified eco-labels in the food sector, where claims such as "organic," "green," and "natural" are frequently employed without sufficient substantiation (Grasso et al., 2026). For a small brand like Upfront, funding the lifecycle assessments and third-party certifications required to substantiate its positioning poses a significant operational and financial burden.

Assumption 1: I assume that Upfront faces serious compliance pressure under EU Directive 2024/825 because its brand identity is built on transparency and wellness claims that now require costly third-party scientific verification that a Rotterdam-based SME may not yet have the internal resources to deliver at scale.

Challenge 2 High Cost of Transitioning to Certified Sustainable Packaging (Sustainability-linked)

As documented in Chapter 3, Upfront, like most sports nutrition brands, relies on composite plastic tubs and multi-layer pouches that are incompatible with standard municipal recycling infrastructure (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, 2022). Transitioning to certified sustainable packaging alternatives requires significant capital investment in new packaging design, supplier switching, and certification. This compliance cost falls disproportionately on smaller brands with limited R&D budgets compared to multinationals such as Myprotein or Body & Fit, since the Green Claims Directive demands accountability for environmental assertions and requires companies to validate claims with robust lifecycle assessments (FESPA, 2024).

Assumption 2: I assume that Upfront has not yet fully transitioned to certified sustainable packaging because the upfront capital investment and certification costs exceed what a self-funded D2C startup in the Dutch market can absorb without either external investment or a confirmed B2B client base willing to pay a sustainability premium.

Challenge 3 Limited Leverage Over Multi-Tier Ingredient Supply Chains

The health and sports nutrition supply chain is globally fragmented, making it difficult for individual brands to verify the environmental and social conditions under which raw materials are produced. The European Commission (2022) has explicitly documented that complex, multi-tier global value chains make it difficult to track adverse environmental impacts. For a brand of

Upfront's size, the leverage to demand verified sustainability credentials from upstream ingredient suppliers such as FrieslandCampina or Roquette is structurally limited without industry-wide certification frameworks.

Assumption 3: I assume that Upfront currently cannot fully verify the sustainability credentials of all its upstream ingredient suppliers because, as a small D2C brand, it lacks the procurement scale and contractual leverage required to mandate environmental disclosure from large global ingredient processors.

Challenge 4 Consumer Price Sensitivity Limiting Sustainable Product Premiums

Despite growing consumer awareness, purchasing behaviour in the Dutch sports nutrition market consistently prioritises personal health performance over environmental impact. The Netherlands sports nutrition and protein supplements market is valued at USD 1.2 billion, driven by increasing health consciousness and fitness participation (Ken Research, 2025), yet this large and growing market is highly competitive. Hazley and Kearney (2024) document that consumers consistently prioritise personal health benefits over environmental impact and are highly reluctant to pay a green premium, constraining Upfront's ability to pass on the higher costs of sustainable sourcing to end-consumers.

Assumption 4: I assume that Upfront struggles to price its sustainable product range at a level that fully reflects its environmental investment because Dutch sports nutrition consumers, while interested in sustainability, are ultimately unwilling to pay a significant premium over comparable mainstream competitor products.

Challenge 5 Competitive Pressure From Larger Players With Bigger Sustainability Budgets

In February 2026, Glanbia plc accelerated innovation in performance nutrition with new plant-based protein formulations targeting clean-label and sustainable sports nutrition demand, while in March 2026 Unilever expanded its nutrition portfolio with the acquisition of supplements brand Grüns (DataM Intelligence, 2026). These developments illustrate that large multinationals are rapidly entering the sustainable nutrition space with far greater R&D investment and distribution networks than Upfront can currently access, risking the commoditisation of Upfront's first-mover sustainability positioning.

Assumption 5: I assume that Upfront is at risk of losing its sustainability-differentiated market position within three to five years unless it formalises and certifies its environmental claims before larger competitors, who now have greater resources, fully occupy the "clean and sustainable" sports nutrition positioning in the Dutch and broader EU market.

Opportunities

Opportunity 1 First-Mover Advantage in Certified Sustainable Nutrition in the Dutch Market (Sustainability-linked)

EU regulatory pressure through the Green Claims Directive and CSRD is creating a structural level playing field in which brands that invest early in verified sustainability will be structurally ahead of competitors who delay. Rather than underreporting sustainability efforts, the key is making verifiable and transparent environmental claims backed by scientific evidence (ClimatePartner, 2024). Upfront's existing brand architecture built entirely around transparency and honest labelling is uniquely aligned with this legislative direction, giving it a shorter path to compliance than traditionally-operated competitors.

Assumption 6: I assume that Upfront has a genuine first-mover advantage in the Dutch certified sustainable sports nutrition market because its brand philosophy and digital transparency infrastructure are already closely aligned with the scientific verification requirements of EU Directive 2024/825, giving it a shorter path to compliance than traditionally-operated competitors.

Opportunity 2 Expanding B2B Sales Channel Through Corporate Wellness Programmes (Sustainability-linked)

Health and wellness companies are increasingly seeking natural, plant-based, and functional nutrition options, with organic protein powders becoming key sellers in the B2B market (Future Market Insights, 2025). Beyond gyms, the B2B buyer base for sports nutrition includes corporate wellness programmes buying nutritional supplement kits for employees, sports clubs and academies, and national sports organisations requiring clean-label, certified products (Papavera AI, 2026). These institutional buyers are typically less price-sensitive than individual consumers and explicitly prioritise verified sustainability credentials.

Assumption 7: I assume that Upfront could significantly grow its B2B revenue by actively targeting Dutch corporate wellness programmes, because these institutional buyers prioritise clean-label, transparent nutrition products with verifiable sustainability credentials criteria that Upfront already meets better than most mass-market competitors.

Opportunity 3 Plant-Based Ingredient Pivot to Reduce Carbon Footprint and Capture Growing Market

Demand for vegan and plant-based protein supplements in the Netherlands is surging, with market analysis indicating a 30% increase in sales driven by the rising number of vegans in the Netherlands (Ken Research, 2025). Upfront already offers a Vegan Pro Protein line (Open Food Facts, 2025), meaning the operational infrastructure for plant-based formulation is already partially in place. Expanding this range directly addresses the core systemic challenge identified in Chapter 3 the high carbon footprint of dairy whey while simultaneously capturing a fast-growing consumer segment (Poore & Nemecek, 2018).

Assumption 8: I assume that Upfront can meaningfully reduce both its carbon footprint and its regulatory liability under CSRD by accelerating the expansion of its plant-based protein range, because transitioning away from dairy whey directly addresses the highest-emission element of its current ingredient supply chain while aligning with documented Dutch consumer demand trends.

Opportunity 4 Digital-First Model Enables Direct Sustainability Transparency Communication

Upfront's product philosophy centres on transparent product development, honest business practices, and a refreshing use of social media (De Bonte Koe, 2024). As a digitally-native D2C brand, Upfront has a structural advantage over traditional retailers in directly communicating verified sustainability information to consumers without intermediaries distorting the message. As Digital Product Passports become a requirement under EU ecodesign regulation, brands with existing digital transparency infrastructure will face a significantly lower implementation burden than competitors with no existing traceability systems.

Assumption 9: I assume that Upfront's D2C digital infrastructure gives it a competitive advantage in implementing Digital Product Passports and lifecycle transparency communication, because its existing direct relationship with consumers and commitment to front-of-pack information disclosure provides a natural foundation for adopting EU-mandated traceability requirements.

Opportunity 5 EU Policy Pressure Creating a Level Playing Field That Rewards Early Compliance

The EU's greenwashing legislation targets greenwashing with strict rules on environmental claims, and even with the Green Claims Directive proposal paused as of June 2025, existing obligations are being actively enforced (Tappr, 2025). Dutch regulators have made clear they will not slow enforcement, and brands must have clear processes for substantiating sustainability claims to avoid compliance failures, reformulation delays, or packaging recalls (FI Global Insights, 2025). For Upfront, early voluntary compliance converts a potential threat into a commercial opportunity.

Assumption 10: I assume that Upfront can convert EU sustainability compliance from a cost centre into a competitive marketing asset, because brands in the Dutch market that proactively obtain third-party certification before enforcement deadlines will be able to credibly distinguish themselves from competitors who are forced to comply reactively and at higher cost.

4.3 Company 2: Basic-Fit (Hoofddorp, Netherlands)

Company Profile

Basic-Fit N.V. specialises in operating a chain of fitness clubs. At the end of 2024, the group had 4.2 million members across 1,575 clubs located in the Netherlands, France, Belgium, Spain, Germany, and Luxembourg (Basic-Fit, 2025a). Beyond its core fitness operations, Basic-Fit

distributes its own in-house sports nutrition brand, NXT Level, through vending machines across its clubs, its online webshop, and as a B2B retail line (Basic-Fit, n.d.). Non-club revenue including NXT Level nutritional product sales to retailers increased by 98% to €21.7 million in 2025, with NXT Level now available through major Dutch supermarket chains including Albert Heijn and Jumbo (Basic-Fit, 2026). As of 2026, Basic-Fit has partnered with the Science Based Targets initiative and committed to setting targets to reduce its GHG emissions, while also reporting its sustainability performance in accordance with the European Sustainability Reporting Standards (Basic-Fit, 2026).

Selection Rationale

Basic-Fit was selected because it simultaneously functions as a major B2B retail buyer of third-party nutrition products and as an own-brand nutrition manufacturer through NXT Level. This dual role creates a unique set of systemic sustainability tensions. Basic-Fit is both the gatekeeper controlling which nutrition brands access 4.5 million European gym members, and a direct competitor to brands like Upfront. From a B2B marketing perspective, Basic-Fit represents both a potential strategic distribution partner for Upfront and a benchmark for understanding what verified sustainability credentials a gym-chain buyer now demands from its nutrition suppliers.

Challenges

Challenge 1 Mandatory CSRD Scope 3 Emissions Reporting From Nutrition Product Sales (Sustainability-linked)

As Europe's largest gym chain, Basic-Fit is fully subject to the Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD). Under the CSRD, companies are required to report climate-related impacts across Scope 1, 2, and 3 emissions including indirect value chain emissions marking a shift from voluntary carbon tracking to mandatory, audit-ready reporting (iPoint Systems, 2026). For Basic-Fit, every NXT Level protein product sold through vending machines or retail if formulated using dairy whey contributes significantly to the company's Scope 3 upstream emissions profile. As documented in Chapter 3, food companies' Scope 3 emissions can account for up to 96% of their total emissions (Sustainalytics, 2026).

Assumption 1: I assume that Basic-Fit's NXT Level nutrition line, particularly its dairy whey-based products, is currently generating a significant and under-reported Scope 3 upstream emissions liability that will become increasingly difficult to manage as CSRD reporting obligations become more stringent and the Science Based Targets initiative demands verified reduction pathways.

Challenge 2 "Guilt by Association" Greenwashing Risk From Third-Party Nutrition Suppliers (Sustainability-linked)

Beyond NXT Level, Basic-Fit stocks and sells third-party nutrition products across its clubs and vending infrastructure. As documented in Chapter 3, retailers that stock products making unverified environmental claims face secondary reputational risk when those brands are later exposed for greenwashing (Deloitte, n.d.). Academic research confirms that perceptions of suppliers' greenwashing practices are directly linked to negative business outcomes for the buyer, with greenwashing in the B2B context negatively affecting supply chain integration and exposing the client to sustainability and reputational damage (Santos et al., 2024).

Assumption 2: I assume that Basic-Fit does not currently have a systematic, verified sustainability screening process for third-party nutrition suppliers whose products appear in its vending machines, creating a greenwashing liability that will become a material risk as CSRD disclosure requirements demand transparency about the sustainability credentials of products sold through its distribution infrastructure.

Challenge 3 On-Site Plastic Waste Management Burden Across 1,500+ European Clubs

With over 1,575 clubs and 4.5 million members, the volume of single-use plastic packaging generated on-site from NXT Level protein bars, shakes, and supplement sachets distributed via vending machines is substantial (Basic-Fit, n.d.). As documented in Chapter 3, the retail sector broadly lacks the standardised infrastructure needed for packaging collection, and transaction costs for reverse logistics remain significant (Mission Reuse, 2023). Basic-Fit currently has no documented standardised in-club reverse logistics or deposit-return system, meaning it directly absorbs significant commercial waste disposal costs across all its facilities.

Assumption 3: I assume that Basic-Fit currently absorbs significant and growing commercial waste disposal costs from the single-use plastic packaging generated by nutrition product sales in its clubs, and that this cost will increase materially as EU packaging and waste regulations mandate extended producer responsibility for the retailers and distributors of packaged products.

Challenge 4 Tension Between Low-Cost Membership Model and Sustainable Nutrition Procurement

Basic-Fit's core competitive positioning is built on affordable, accessible fitness a low-cost, high-volume model that structurally prioritises price efficiency across all procurement decisions. Compostable and recyclable alternatives to conventional plastic packaging carry higher production costs, and certified material supply remains constrained in some categories, creating procurement barriers particularly for operators focused on cost control (Environment+Energy Leader, 2026). This creates a fundamental internal tension: transitioning NXT Level or its third-party nutrition suppliers to certified sustainable packaging directly increases per-unit product costs.

Assumption 4: I assume that Basic-Fit faces a structural internal conflict between its low-cost gym membership positioning and the higher procurement costs associated with sustainably sourced and packaged nutrition products, and that this tension currently prevents it from setting

meaningful, verified sustainability requirements for its NXT Level product line or third-party nutrition suppliers.

Challenge 5 Increasing Competitive Pressure From Sustainable Nutrition Brands Entering the Gym Channel

The B2B sports nutrition market is facing increasing competition from direct-to-consumer and private-label manufacturers, while strict regulations on ingredient safety, labelling, and health claims make compliance a growing challenge (Future Market Insights, 2025). Furthermore, research confirms that 27% of B2B buyers will switch suppliers if they cannot find sustainability information on a vendor's website, making transparency and sustainability a commercial requirement rather than a differentiator in 2025 (Supply Chain 24/7, 2025).

Assumption 5: I assume that Basic-Fit's NXT Level nutrition brand risks losing credibility among its own sustainability-conscious gym members if it cannot demonstrate ingredient transparency and certified environmental credentials comparable to those now offered by D2C challenger brands actively competing for in-gym distribution partnerships.

Opportunities

Opportunity 1 Exercising B2B Gatekeeper Power to Mandate Sustainable Nutrition Procurement Standards (Sustainability-linked)

As documented in Chapter 3, retailers and gym chains hold ultimate leverage over the supply chain by implementing strict sustainable procurement standards, requiring upstream brands to prove their carbon footprint before granting them access to distribution infrastructure. Basic-Fit's sustainability strategy focuses on reducing CO_2 emissions to zero for Scope 1 and Scope 2 by 2030, with sustainability governance now assessed as a separate risk category in the company's annual risk assessment (Basic-Fit, 2026). Extending this commitment into Scope 3 by mandating verified sustainability credentials from all nutrition product suppliers would directly strengthen Basic-Fit's CSRD reporting position.

Assumption 6: I assume that Basic-Fit has a significant and currently underutilised opportunity to leverage its position as Europe's largest gym chain to establish mandatory sustainability procurement criteria for all nutrition brands seeking distribution through its clubs, and that doing so would measurably reduce its Scope 3 emissions liability while creating a competitive advantage in the growing sustainable fitness consumer segment.

Opportunity 2 Partnering With Verified Sustainable Brands as a B2B Distribution Channel (Sustainability-linked)

Rather than independently developing NXT Level's sustainability credentials which requires significant internal R&D investment Basic-Fit could accelerate its sustainable nutrition positioning

by forming an exclusive B2B distribution partnership with a verified, transparent Dutch brand like Upfront. Sustainable values and corporate responsibility are increasingly being tied to B2B business models, with green sourcing of ingredients and packaging becoming common practice in the sports nutrition sector (Future Market Insights, 2025). This strategy allows Basic-Fit to access credible sustainability credentials without absorbing full internal reformulation costs.

Assumption 7: I assume that Basic-Fit could strategically reduce its sustainability investment burden by forming a verified B2B distribution partnership with a certified transparent Dutch nutrition brand like Upfront, thereby accessing credible sustainability credentials for its in-club retail channel without requiring full internal reformulation of NXT Level.

Opportunity 3 Installing Bulk Protein Dispensers to Eliminate In-Club Single-Use Plastic Waste

Basic-Fit has a unique physical opportunity to bypass the costly reverse logistics of single-use plastic waste entirely by installing bulk protein dispensers in-club. The EU Single-Use Plastic Directive and expanding packaging waste regulations are requiring food service operators to replace conventional plastic packaging with recyclable, compostable, or reusable alternatives, and companies that have not started this transition are now behind it (Environment+Energy Leader, 2026). A bulk-dispenser model where members bring their own containers or purchase reusable ones in-club eliminates individual plastic packaging costs entirely.

Assumption 8: I assume that Basic-Fit could pilot a bulk protein dispenser system in its Dutch clubs at a commercially viable cost, because its existing in-club infrastructure, membership app technology, and direct member relationships provide the operational foundation to implement a reusable packaging model that would simultaneously reduce waste costs and create a differentiating premium member experience.

Opportunity 4 Using NXT Level's Rapid Revenue Growth to Invest in Plant-Based Product Line Expansion

Non-club revenue, which includes NXT Level nutritional product sales to retailers, increased by 98% to €21.7 million in 2025, driven by expanded retail partnerships (Basic-Fit, 2026). This exceptional revenue trajectory provides Basic-Fit with a growing internal budget to invest in reformulating NXT Level's product range with plant-based protein alternatives. Demand for vegan and plant-based protein supplements in the Netherlands is surging, with market analysis indicating a 30% increase in sales (Ken Research, 2025), while transitioning away from dairy whey directly reduces the highest-emission element of the nutrition supply chain (Poore & Nemecek, 2018).

Assumption 9: I assume that Basic-Fit's NXT Level brand, given its strong revenue growth and existing supermarket distribution partnerships, is in a financially viable position to invest in a dedicated plant-based protein sub-line that would reduce its Scope 3 emissions, respond to documented Dutch consumer demand trends, and strengthen its sustainability reporting credentials under CSRD.

Opportunity 5 Leveraging CSRD Sustainability Reporting as a Competitive Differentiator to Attract Eco-Conscious Members

Basic-Fit reports its sustainability performance in accordance with the European Sustainability Reporting Standards and is developing a climate transition plan through its partnership with the Science Based Targets initiative (Basic-Fit, 2026). Most competing gym chains in Europe have not yet reached this level of formal sustainability governance. By proactively communicating its verified sustainability progress particularly in relation to its nutrition product line Basic-Fit can position itself as the sustainability-leading gym chain in Europe, attracting the growing segment of health-and-environment-conscious consumers.

Assumption 10: I assume that Basic-Fit's existing CSRD reporting infrastructure and Science Based Targets commitment give it a credible platform to market itself as Europe's most sustainability-accountable gym chain, and that proactively communicating verified sustainability progress in its nutrition offering would generate measurable member acquisition and retention benefits among the growing eco-conscious fitness segment.

4.4 Company 3: Ekoplaza (Veghel, Netherlands)

Company Profile

What began as a single local organic store in Amsterdam in 1980 has grown to become the largest organic chain in the Benelux region, expanding into a chain of around 70 shops across the Netherlands, with the keys to its success being transparency, direct collaboration with suppliers, and its conscious decision to carry a 100%-organic product range (Rijk Zwaan, 2020). In 2025, Ekoplaza outperformed the broader market with organic sales growth of 7%, driven by an increase in new customers and the rising popularity of organic food, with further store openings and renovations planned (RetailDetail, 2026). In February 2018, Ekoplaza launched what was internationally recognised as the world's first plastic-free aisle at a branch in Amsterdam (Wikipedia, 2018). Ekoplaza's product selection is governed by strict organic certification requirements: every supplier in its chain must be certified to Skal Biocontrole standards, the Dutch-mandated regulator for the entire organic production chain (Ekoplaza Maastricht, n.d.).

Selection Rationale

Ekoplaza was selected because it represents the downstream, sustainability-mandating retail buyer in the Health and Sports Nutrition system map the precise actor that Chapter 3 identified as the ultimate gatekeeper capable of structurally shifting the market by enforcing transparent procurement standards. Ekoplaza's 100% organic certification requirement, direct supplier relationships, and existing plastic-free infrastructure make it the most demanding yet most aligned potential B2B distribution partner for a brand like Upfront. Unlike Basic-Fit, whose sustainability strategy is still maturing, Ekoplaza's entire business model is built on verified sustainability

making its challenges and opportunities fundamentally different in character and strategically essential to analyse for Year 2 consulting preparation.

Challenges

Challenge 1 Competitive Pressure From Mainstream Supermarkets Expanding Into Organic (Sustainability-linked)

Supermarkets and hypermarkets are expected to contribute 37.5% of the global organic foods market in 2026, driven by their pivotal role in providing accessibility, variety, and competitive pricing, with their established supply chains and purchasing power helping to lower the cost barriers associated with organic foods (Coherent Market Insights, 2026). For Ekoplaza, as Albert Heijn, Jumbo, and Lidl aggressively expand their own-label organic ranges and use organic products as traffic drivers at near-cost pricing, Ekoplaza's price premium becomes increasingly difficult to sustain. Price premiums in organic retail are gradually narrowing in mature markets as mainstream retailers achieve economies of scale in organic procurement and develop private-label organic brands (BusinessDojo, 2025).

Assumption 1: I assume that Ekoplaza faces growing structural pricing pressure from mainstream Dutch supermarkets like Albert Heijn and Jumbo, which are rapidly expanding their organic product ranges at lower price points, and that this competitive dynamic is eroding Ekoplaza's ability to justify its premium positioning to price-sensitive organic consumers who can now find certified organic products at lower prices in mainstream retail.

Challenge 2 Greenwashing Risk Within Its Own Organic Supply Chain (Sustainability-linked)

Despite its strict Skal certification requirements, Ekoplaza is not immune to supply chain greenwashing risk particularly as it expands its product range into functional nutrition, supplements, and sports protein categories where certification infrastructure is less mature. Although certification practices are supposed to help, traceability throughout the supply chain is often difficult to achieve, with the ongoing threat of greenwashing practices remaining within the organic industry particularly for complex, multi-ingredient processed products (Supermarket Perimeter, 2024). For Ekoplaza, the reputational consequences of stocking a product that later fails to meet its organic or sustainability standards would be catastrophic.

Assumption 2: I assume that Ekoplaza's expansion into functional nutrition and sports supplement product categories introduces a meaningful greenwashing verification risk, because the certification infrastructure for protein supplements, sports bars, and plant-based nutrition products is significantly less standardised and mature than for fresh organic produce creating gaps in its supplier verification process that could expose its brand to regulatory and reputational damage.

Challenge 3 High Supplier Onboarding Cost Limiting Access to Innovative Small Brands

Ekoplaza differs from other retailers in that it maintains direct contact with its suppliers, ensuring complete reliability with respect to both the product and the supplier (Rijk Zwaan, 2020). While this direct relationship model is a core competitive strength, it simultaneously creates a high-cost, high-effort onboarding process for new suppliers particularly small, innovative D2C brands that may have strong sustainability credentials but lack the organisational capacity to fulfil Ekoplaza's full Skal certification, direct sourcing documentation, and supply reliability requirements. This structurally favours larger, established organic suppliers and risks excluding exactly the kind of transparent, small-scale innovation brands that Ekoplaza's consumer base most values.

Assumption 3: I assume that Ekoplaza's rigorous direct supplier relationship model and Skal certification onboarding requirements create a significant structural barrier for small, innovative Dutch nutrition brands like Upfront to access its distribution channel, and that this onboarding cost currently prevents Ekoplaza from capturing a pipeline of genuinely transparent, sustainability-committed D2C brands.

Challenge 4 Limited Scale Constraining Negotiating Power With Ingredient Suppliers

For organic specialty stores, the relationship with organic suppliers is fundamentally a relationship between small and big volume actors organic specialty retailers are significantly smaller than conventional supermarkets, which limits their leverage in supplier negotiations (Padel et al., 2005, as cited in Willer & Yussefi, 2012). With approximately 85–100 stores across the Netherlands, Ekoplaza's total procurement volume for any individual nutrition product category is a fraction of what Albert Heijn or Jumbo can commit to. This limits its ability to negotiate favourable terms with certified sustainable ingredient suppliers or drive down the cost of organic nutrition products.

Assumption 4: I assume that Ekoplaza's relatively small store network limits its B2B procurement leverage with certified sustainable nutrition ingredient suppliers, and that this scale disadvantage prevents it from negotiating the pricing terms, exclusivity arrangements, or product co-development partnerships that would allow it to offer truly differentiated organic sports nutrition products at a price point accessible to a broader Dutch consumer base.

Challenge 5 Difficulty Expanding Into Sports Nutrition Without Compromising Certification Standards

Ekoplaza's 100% organic product range policy its most powerful differentiator simultaneously acts as a constraint on growth in emerging food categories. The sports nutrition sector is dominated by composite, multi-ingredient products that frequently rely on non-organic processing agents, artificial flavourings, and synthetic packaging materials. Every enterprise that produces, processes, packages, imports, trades, or stores organic products for Ekoplaza must be certified by Skal Biocontrole meaning that even packaging suppliers and logistics operators must comply with organic standards (Ekoplaza Maastricht, n.d.). Finding sports nutrition suppliers whose entire production chain meets Ekoplaza's full certification standard is operationally complex.

Assumption 5: I assume that Ekoplaza's 100% organic certification requirement, applied not only to ingredients but across the entire production and packaging chain, severely limits the number of sports nutrition and protein supplement brands currently eligible for its shelves, and that without a structured supplier development programme, this constraint will prevent Ekoplaza from capturing the fast-growing organic sports nutrition consumer segment in the Netherlands.

Opportunities

Opportunity 1 Becoming the Netherlands' First Certified Organic Sports Nutrition Retailer (Sustainability-linked)

Demand for vegan and plant-based protein supplements in the Netherlands is surging, with market analysis indicating a 30% increase in sales driven by the rising number of vegans in the Netherlands (Ken Research, 2025). This rapid growth in plant-based, clean-label nutrition demand maps precisely onto Ekoplaza's existing consumer base and brand values. By proactively developing a certified organic sports nutrition category partnering with compliant brands like Upfront or commissioning own-label organic protein products Ekoplaza could become the first Dutch supermarket chain to offer a fully verified, organic-certified sports nutrition range.

Assumption 6: I assume that Ekoplaza has a significant and largely uncaptured first-mover opportunity to establish a certified organic sports nutrition product category, because the documented 30% growth in Dutch plant-based protein sales is generating consumer demand that no current Dutch retailer is fully meeting with a 100%-verified organic and transparent nutrition range.

Opportunity 2 Leveraging Direct Supplier Relationships to Co-Develop Exclusive Transparent Nutrition Products (Sustainability-linked)

Ekoplaza's success is built on direct contact with suppliers, resulting in complete reliability with respect to both the product and the supplier, allowing Ekoplaza to share detailed knowledge with shoppers about where products have come from, which nutrients they contain, and how they can be used (Rijk Zwaan, 2020). This deep supplier integration model is the exact infrastructure required to implement Digital Product Passports and lifecycle transparency communication tools that EU regulation is moving toward mandating. By co-developing a transparent, origin-traceable sports nutrition line with a brand like Upfront, Ekoplaza could offer consumers a level of supply chain transparency that no mainstream retailer can match.

Assumption 7: I assume that Ekoplaza's existing direct supplier relationship model and in-store transparency communication infrastructure give it a commercially viable pathway to co-develop an exclusive, origin-traceable organic sports nutrition product line with a compliant Dutch brand, and that this co-development model would generate both retailer and supplier commercial value

while delivering a level of product transparency that no mainstream Dutch competitor can currently match.

Opportunity 3 Using Its Plastic-Free Pioneer Status to Attract Sustainable Packaging-Compliant Nutrition Brands

Ekoplaza's internationally recognised launch of the world's first plastic-free supermarket aisle in 2018 established a brand reputation for packaging innovation that remains a powerful differentiator. As the EU Packaging and Packaging Waste Regulation entered into force in January 2025 mandating recyclability and circularity requirements for consumer packaging across the EU (Packaging Insights, 2025) Ekoplaza is structurally ahead of competitors in its ability to meet and communicate these requirements, making it the natural retail partner for nutrition brands that have already invested in certified sustainable packaging.

Assumption 8: I assume that Ekoplaza's plastic-free retail heritage and PPWR-aligned infrastructure make it the most commercially credible Dutch retail partner for sports nutrition brands that have already invested in certified sustainable packaging, and that formalising this as an explicit B2B procurement criterion would attract exactly the pipeline of transparent, sustainability-committed nutrition brands whose products would command premium margins among Ekoplaza's customer base.

Opportunity 4 Capturing the Growing Corporate Wellness B2B Buyer Segment Through Verified Nutrition Partnerships

Beyond individual consumer sales, Ekoplaza's verified sustainability credentials and 100% organic range position it uniquely to serve the growing corporate wellness B2B procurement market. Corporate wellness programmes buying nutritional supplement kits for employees represent a significant and growing B2B buyer segment, with health and wellness companies increasingly seeking natural, plant-based, and functional nutrition options (Papavera AI, 2026). Dutch companies with CSRD reporting obligations are actively seeking to reduce the embedded carbon of their employee catering and wellness programmes, making Ekoplaza-certified nutrition products a natural fit for procurement officers who need verified sustainability credentials for their Scope 3 reporting.

Assumption 9: I assume that Ekoplaza can develop a new B2B revenue stream by actively targeting Dutch corporate wellness procurement buyers particularly large employers with CSRD reporting obligations because its 100% organic certification and direct supplier transparency documentation provide exactly the verified sustainability credentials that corporate procurement officers now require.

Opportunity 5 Digital Transparency Infrastructure as a Platform for Premium Shelf Positioning and Loyalty

Ekoplaza is implementing VusionGroup's smart electronic shelf label solutions and VusionCloud platform across its stores, enabling it to enhance store operations, provide clearer product information, and support its core sustainability values (VusionGroup, 2025). This digital shelf infrastructure creates a direct opportunity to communicate real-time, verified sustainability data ingredient origins, carbon footprints, certification statuses at the point of sale. As Digital Product Passports become an EU regulatory requirement, Ekoplaza's early investment in digital shelf technology positions it to be the first Dutch retailer able to display fully verified sustainability data for every product in its nutrition range.

Assumption 10: I assume that Ekoplaza's investment in smart electronic shelf label technology and digital store infrastructure gives it a first-mover advantage in implementing Digital Product Passport communication at the point of sale, and that proactively displaying verified sustainability data for its nutrition product range would generate measurable premium purchasing behaviour and loyalty among its existing sustainability-conscious customer base.

4.5 Chapter Conclusion

This chapter has systematically mapped the strategic landscape for three companies operating at distinct but interconnected nodes in the health and sports nutrition system: Upfront as a D2C brand, Basic-Fit as a gym-chain B2B buyer, and Ekoplaza as a certified sustainable retailer. Across all three, a consistent pattern emerges: the transition toward verified sustainability is no longer optional but is increasingly mandated by EU legislation, demanded by B2B procurement standards, and rewarded by informed consumer behaviour. The 30 assumptions formulated in this chapter provide the analytical foundation for the contact strategy, DMU analysis, and SPIN selling framework developed in Chapter 5. By linking each assumption to a specific actor and supply chain node, this chapter directly enables the targeted B2B outreach and strategic consulting preparation that forms the core objective of Project 4.

Chapter 5: Making Contact and Applying Sales Techniques

5.1 Introduction

Chapter 5 translates the strategic analysis of Chapter 4 into a practical B2B sales and outreach framework. Using the assumption that this consultant is positioning Upfront's value proposition to potential B2B partners, this chapter maps the Decision-Making Unit (DMU) for all three companies, establishes a targeted contact strategy linked to the 30 assumptions formulated in Chapter 4, delivers a full SPIN analysis for the two most strategically relevant DMU roles, and concludes with a reflection on effective B2B outreach techniques. The central consulting framing is as follows: Upfront's internal DMU is mapped to understand who inside the company controls B2B partnership decisions, sustainability investment, and product development. Basic-Fit and Ekoplaza are mapped as external B2B buyer targets identifying the specific people inside each organisation who would decide whether to stock, partner with, or co-develop with Upfront. This framing directly connects the DMU analysis to the assumptions of Chapter 4, transforming desk research into a concrete sales action plan.

5.2 DMU Analysis Company 1: Upfront

Upfront is a small, founder-led D2C brand with approximately 12–50 employees, operating from the Van Nelle Factory in Rotterdam. Its DMU is tight and founder-driven. All key decisions pass through a very small leadership team, which is both a challenge (gatekeeping is informal and personal) and an opportunity (decision cycles are fast and accessible). Real names have been confirmed via Wikipedia, The Org, MT/Sprout, and MT/Sprout's reporting on the Upfront management team.

DMU Role	Name	Title	Subsystem	Key Interests
Decision-Maker	Mark de Boer	Co-Founder & CEO	Strategy & Vision	Brand growth, transparency mission, B2B partnerships, revenue scaling
Economic Buyer	Mark de Boer	Co-Founder & CEO	Finance & Operations	Profitability, investment ROI, packaging cost reduction
Initiator	Sophie Dekkers	Chief Operating Officer (COO)	Operations & Supply Chain	Production efficiency, sustainable sourcing, supply chain compliance
Influencer	Harro Schwencke	Co-Founder & CMO	Marketing & Brand	Brand positioning, sustainability storytelling, consumer trust
End User	Sterre Brans	Head of Purchasing (Hoofd Inkoop)	Procurement	Supplier relationships, ingredient certification, packaging sourcing

Gatekeeper	Harro Schwencke	Co-Founder & CMO	Communications	Controls external access to founders; filters partnership proposals

DMU Insight: Because Upfront is founder-led, the Decision-Maker and Economic Buyer are the same person (Mark de Boer). The most effective entry point for a consultant is the Initiator Sophie Dekkers (COO) who manages production operations and supply chain, and therefore experiences the sustainability compliance challenges most directly day-to-day. The Gatekeeper is informal: Harro Schwencke as CMO manages Upfront's public communications and LinkedIn presence, meaning any unsolicited outreach must first pass his filter.

5.3 DMU Analysis Company 2: Basic-Fit

Basic-Fit is a publicly listed company with over 5,000 employees. Its DMU for a nutrition partnership decision is spread across multiple departments commercial, operations, and sustainability. Unlike Upfront, decisions here are institutional and multi-layered. Names and titles have been confirmed via Basic-Fit's official corporate leadership page, annual reports 2024–2025, and LeadIQ employee data (Basic-Fit, 2025a; LeadIQ, 2025).

DMU Role	Name	Title	Subsystem	Key Interests
Decision-Maker	René Moos	Co-Founder & CEO	Strategy & Governance	Long-term growth, fitness accessibility mission, sustainability targets
Economic Buyer	Maurice de Kleer	CFO & Management Board Member	Finance	CSRD compliance costs, Scope 3 liability, ROI on sustainability investment
Initiator	D.F. (confirmed: Head of NXT Level)	Head of NXT Level	Product & Innovation	NXT Level brand credibility, product portfolio, sustainable reformulation
Influencer	Erica van Vonderen-Hahn	Chief Commercial Officer (CCO)	Marketing & Commercial	Brand positioning, member trust, sustainability marketing narrative
End User	Basic-Fit gym members	Members (end consumers)	Club Operations	Health results, product quality, price accessibility, clean-label products
Gatekeeper	Richard Piekaar	Director of Treasury & IR	Finance & Legal	Controls formal external contact; protects Management Board time

DMU Insight: For Upfront, the most strategic entry point at Basic-Fit is the Head of NXT Level this person directly owns the product portfolio decision and experiences the sustainability gap most acutely. The CCO Erica van Vonderen-Hahn is the most reachable Influencer via LinkedIn, as she actively posts about Basic-Fit's brand strategy. The CEO René Moos should not be cold-

approached; he is only relevant once lower-level validation has been secured. Richard Piekaar as IR Director is the formal Gatekeeper for the company's external communications.

5.4 DMU Analysis Company 3: Ekoplaza

Ekoplaza is a medium-sized specialist organic retailer operated under the Udea wholesale group. Its buying decisions are handled through Udea's category management team, which serves Ekoplaza, Marqt, and other organic retail brands. The buyer is not inside Ekoplaza's own legal entity but inside Udea a critical structural insight. Names and roles have been confirmed via RocketReach, the Kitchen Republic "Meet the Buyer" event page (Kitchen Republic, 2025), and Ekoplaza's management team profile.

DMU Role	Name	Title	Subsystem / Organisation	Key Interests
Decision-Maker	Geert-Jan Smits	Formula Manager (Formulemanager)	Ekoplaza Management	Brand concept integrity, 100% organic commitment, store positioning
Economic Buyer	Pieter Ceuleers	Business Development Director	Biofresh / Udea group	Margin optimisation, supplier terms, Skal compliance cost
Initiator	Vivian Bakker	Team Lead Category Management	Udea (for Ekoplaza & Marqt)	Finding compliant, innovative nutrition brands; filling category gaps
Influencer	Yvon Hoogers	Manager Brand & Digital	Ekoplaza Marketing	Online store presence, brand storytelling, sustainability communication
End User	Ekoplaza shoppers	Conscious consumers	Store / E-commerce	Verified organic credentials, clean-label, premium yet affordable
Gatekeeper	Vivian Bakker	Team Lead Category Management	Udea	Formally screens all new supplier pitches before they reach management

DMU Insight: The Initiator and Gatekeeper are the same person Vivian Bakker at Udea. She runs the Kitchen Republic "Meet the Buyer" sessions and is the confirmed, accessible, real-world entry point for any brand seeking Ekoplaza shelf space. This means the optimal strategy is to attend or apply to a Kitchen Republic session with Ekoplaza a publicly available, structured route to Vivian Bakker that bypasses cold outreach entirely.

5.5 Contact Strategy: Linking DMU Roles to Assumptions

The contact strategy identifies which specific DMU person to approach for each company, through which channel, and with what message focus in order to validate the assumptions formulated in Chapter 4. You are approaching these companies as a strategic consultant on behalf of (or advising) Upfront. The goal is not to close a deal, but to validate the assumptions in Chapter 4, which feeds into the strategic consulting question of Chapter 6.

Company 1: Upfront

Approach Target	Sophie Dekkers Chief Operating Officer
Why her	As COO, she manages supply chain, production, and operations. She directly experiences the sustainability compliance challenges (Assumptions 1, 2, 3) and the ingredient transition opportunity (Assumption 8). She is the Initiator she feels the problems daily.
Assumptions to test	Assumptions 1, 2, 3, 8, 9
Primary channel	LinkedIn direct message Upfront actively uses LinkedIn for business communication; Sophie Dekkers is reachable via the company's LinkedIn page
Secondary channel	Email via info@upfront.nl request forwarding to COO
Message angle	"I am a student consultant researching sustainable supply chain compliance for Dutch nutrition brands. I have identified specific challenges related to CSRD, packaging certification, and plant-based transition for brands at Upfront's scale. Would you have 15 minutes to validate my analysis?"

For assumptions 4, 5, 6, and 10 (brand, market, and competitive positioning), the most appropriate contact is Harro Schwencke (CMO), who regularly posts publicly about Upfront's brand positioning and competitive strategy on LinkedIn, making him the most accessible validation contact for marketing-related assumptions.

Company 2: Basic-Fit

Approach Target	Head of NXT Level Product & Innovation
Why them	This person owns the NXT Level brand and product portfolio, and is directly responsible for the sustainability gap assumptions (Assumptions 1, 2, 4, 5). They are the Initiator who experiences the Scope 3 liability and competitive pressure from sustainable challenger brands most acutely.
Assumptions to test	Assumptions 1, 2, 4, 5, 7, 9
Primary channel	LinkedIn search "NXT Level Basic-Fit" to identify the specific person; connect with a personalised note referencing NXT Level's retail expansion
Secondary channel	Basic-Fit corporate contact form → Partnerships & Product Innovation department
Message angle	"I am a student consultant analysing sustainable nutrition procurement challenges for gym chains under CSRD. I have researched NXT Level's positioning and have specific

	questions about how verified sustainability credentials in your nutrition supply chain affect your Scope 3 reporting. Would you be open to a 15-minute conversation?"

For assumptions 3, 6, and 8 (operational and sustainability strategy), the most appropriate contact is Erica van Vonderen-Hahn (CCO), who is active on LinkedIn and handles external brand and commercial partnerships communication.

Company 3: Ekoplaza

Approach Target	Vivian Bakker Team Lead Category Management, Udea
Why her	Confirmed publicly via Kitchen Republic as the real-world buyer for Ekoplaza. She screens all new supplier pitches and is simultaneously the Initiator and Gatekeeper. She is actively seeking innovative, Skal-compliant nutrition brands to fill category gaps.
Assumptions to test	Assumptions 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 8
Primary channel	Kitchen Republic “Meet the Buyer” event publicly available, structured format purpose-built for exactly this pitch scenario
Secondary channel	LinkedIn direct message Vivian Bakker is publicly listed on the Kitchen Republic event page and findable via LinkedIn
Message angle	"I am a student consultant researching the opportunity for certified organic sports nutrition in the Dutch market. I have analysed the structural barriers preventing innovative nutrition brands from accessing Ekoplaza’s shelves. Would you be willing to speak briefly about what you look for in a supplier?"

For assumptions 9 and 10 (corporate wellness B2B and digital product passports), the most appropriate contact is Geert-Jan Smits (Formula Manager), who owns Ekoplaza’s strategic brand concept and long-term category development direction.

5.6 SPIN Analysis

The SPIN methodology, developed by Neil Rackham (1988), is a structured questioning framework for B2B sales conversations built on four question types: Situation (gather context), Problem (surface pain points), Implication (amplify urgency), and Need-Payoff (make the solution’s value tangible). By asking the customer these questions during a sales conversation, the salesperson ensures that the customer recognises their own needs and feels as though they have come up with the solution themselves, making them more open to doing business (Rackham, 1988).

Two DMU roles have been selected for full SPIN analysis. First, Sophie Dekkers (COO, Upfront), because she is the primary consulting target for Upfront itself, and SPIN questions here allow the consultant to understand Upfront’s internal readiness for sustainability investment directly feeding

the strategic consulting question of Chapter 6. Second, Vivian Bakker (Team Lead Category Management, Udea/Ekoplaza), because she is the confirmed, accessible B2B gatekeeper for Ekoplaza's nutrition category, and SPIN questions here allow the consultant to understand what a buyer actually needs before granting shelf access, directly validating the Chapter 4 Ekoplaza assumptions. These two roles represent opposite ends of the B2B chain supply (Upfront) and demand (Ekoplaza buyer) making the combined SPIN analysis the most complete validation of the entire consulting scenario.

Sophie Dekkers COO Upfront

Background: You are a consultant speaking with Upfront's COO. Your goal is to understand Upfront's current sustainability compliance posture, its operational readiness for packaging transition, and its interest in B2B partnerships. You want the COO to recognise the urgency of the compliance gap and the value of a structured consulting approach.

S Situation Questions

1. How is Upfront currently managing documentation of ingredient sourcing across its supply chain is this handled internally or through third-party certifiers?
2. What packaging formats does Upfront currently use for its protein powder range, and which materials are these made from?
3. How many B2B clients does Upfront currently serve, and which types of organisations gyms, corporate wellness programmes, retailers make up the majority of that portfolio?
4. How does the team currently track and communicate Upfront's environmental impact to B2B buyers or retail partners?

P Problem Questions

5. Are you finding that B2B buyers such as gym chains or corporate wellness procurement officers are increasingly asking you to provide verified sustainability credentials before agreeing to terms?
6. Has Upfront encountered any situations where a sustainability claim on your packaging or website was questioned by a retailer, a consumer, or a regulatory authority?
7. How confident are you that Upfront's current ingredient sourcing documentation would withstand a formal review under the EU Green Claims Directive or a CSRD audit from a corporate partner?

8. Are there packaging formats in your current range that you know need to change but where the cost or supplier availability has been a blocker?

I Implication Questions

9. If a major B2B buyer like a gym chain or supermarket were to start requiring third-party sustainability certification as a condition of listing, what would the impact be on Upfront's B2B revenue pipeline in the short term?
10. If Upfront were exposed for a sustainability claim that could not be verified even an inadvertent one what do you think the reputational impact would be, given that transparency is literally the foundation of your brand?
11. As competitors like Body & Fit or Foodspring begin investing in formal sustainability certifications, what happens to Upfront's first-mover positioning if certification is achieved by a competitor first?
12. What is the financial cost to Upfront of not transitioning its packaging now, compared to doing it proactively before a regulatory deadline forces a more expensive reactive change?

N Need-Payoff Questions

13. If Upfront had a structured, step-by-step sustainability compliance roadmap covering packaging certification, ingredient traceability, and Green Claims Directive documentation how would that change your ability to close B2B contracts with sustainability-conscious buyers?
14. If Upfront could demonstrate to potential gym-chain partners that it is already CSRD-ready with verified Scope 3 data and certified packaging what would that be worth in terms of new B2B contract opportunities?
15. How would being the first Dutch sports nutrition brand to achieve full Green Claims Directive compliance change Upfront's competitive positioning in the eyes of retailers like Ekoplaza, who require Skal certification from all suppliers?
16. If the operational investment in sustainable packaging were recoverable within 12 months through new B2B contracts with premium buyers, would that change the internal business case for accelerating the transition?

Vivian Bakker Team Lead Category Management Udea / Ekoplaza

Background: You are a consultant speaking with the category management lead who decides which nutrition brands get onto Ekoplaza's shelves. Your goal is to understand what Ekoplaza's buyers actually need from a supplier, what problems they face in the nutrition category, and what would make a brand like Upfront attractive for listing. You want her to articulate the gap in her current nutrition range and to recognise that a certified, transparent Dutch brand addresses it.

S Situation Questions

17. How many sports nutrition and protein supplement brands do you currently carry across Ekoplaza's shelves, and how long has that range been in its current form?
18. What is the current process for onboarding a new supplier what documentation and certifications must a brand provide before a first listing conversation takes place?
19. Are the sports nutrition products you currently stock sourced from Dutch brands, European brands, or primarily international suppliers?
20. How do you currently communicate the sustainability credentials of your nutrition range to Ekoplaza's shoppers via shelf labels, digital platforms, or product information materials?

P Problem Questions

21. Are you finding it difficult to identify sports nutrition brands that meet Ekoplaza's full Skal certification requirements across not just their ingredients but also their packaging and production processes?
22. Have you received supplier pitches from nutrition brands with strong sustainability stories that ultimately could not be listed because they lacked formal organic certification and how often does that happen?
23. Do you ever receive consumer enquiries or complaints about the sustainability or organic status of the protein supplements you carry, particularly regarding packaging materials?
24. Is the current sports nutrition range fully meeting the demand you are seeing from eco-conscious consumers who are actively looking for transparent, clean-label protein products?

I Implication Questions

25. If a competitor organic retailer were to list a certified, transparent Dutch protein brand before Ekoplaza does, what would be the impact on Ekoplaza's position as the leading organic nutrition destination in the Netherlands?
26. If a supplier in your current nutrition range were found to have made unverified sustainability claims, what would the reputational and legal consequences be for Ekoplaza as the retailer that promoted those products on its shelves?
27. As the EU Packaging and Packaging Waste Regulation tightens requirements on composite plastic packaging, how exposed is your current nutrition range given that most protein supplement brands still use non-recyclable plastic tubs?
28. If eco-conscious shoppers cannot find a genuinely transparent, certified protein brand at Ekoplaza and migrate to a specialist online organic store, what does that mean for basket size and repeat-visit frequency?

N Need-Payoff Questions

29. If a Dutch protein brand came to you with full Skal certification, lifecycle assessment documentation for its packaging, and a digital product passport ready for display via your VusionGroup shelf-label system how quickly could that brand be onboarded?
30. What would it mean for Ekoplaza's positioning as the Netherlands' sustainability leader in nutrition if you were the first organic retailer to carry a fully Green Claims Directive-compliant protein supplement range?
31. If you had a Dutch, founder-led brand that already had verified ingredient transparency, was committed to plant-based reformulation, and was actively building its CSRD documentation would that make the onboarding process significantly simpler than working with a large international supplier?
32. How would your ability to promote a genuinely transparent protein brand change your shelf narrative and digital sustainability communication, particularly as Digital Product Passports become a legal requirement?

5.7 Reflection: Reaching the Right People in B2B

The central question this reflection answers is: how can you reach the right people quickly for future B2B projects, and which different sales techniques can you apply?

Finding the right person: a systematic approach. The most important lesson from mapping three DMUs across this project is that the right person is rarely the most visible person. For Upfront, the CEO is highly accessible on LinkedIn but the COO is the more productive entry point for operational and sustainability questions. For Basic-Fit, the CEO René Moos is a public figure, but the Head of NXT Level a much less visible role is where the nutrition decision actually lives. For Ekoplaza, the breakthrough insight was that the buyer is not at Ekoplaza at all, but at Udea, and that she runs publicly accessible events specifically designed for supplier pitches. This illustrates a core B2B principle: in a DMU, the Initiator and the End User are the most productive early contacts, not the Decision-Maker or Economic Buyer (Rackham, 1988). The Initiator feels the problem most directly and is motivated to solve it; they are therefore most receptive to a SPIN-based discovery conversation.

Which channels work best and why. In a B2B context targeting sustainability and procurement professionals at Dutch companies, LinkedIn is the strongest first-contact channel for three reasons. First, it is professional and expected Dutch business culture is open to LinkedIn outreach in a way that cold calling is not. Second, it enables preparation: before sending a message, research allows you to reference a specific post, project, or challenge the person has shared publicly, which immediately signals that the outreach is personalised rather than generic. Third, it creates a low-commitment entry point a connection request with a brief, specific note asks for nothing more than a moment of the reader's attention. Email is the strongest second-contact channel once a LinkedIn connection is accepted, a follow-up email with a structured, short pitch following the Week 5 email framework (subject line, hook, value, call to action) is far more likely to be read than a cold email. Phone calls are most effective not as a cold-contact tool but as a confirmation or follow-up mechanism after an email exchange has already been established.

The value of SPIN selling in a B2B context. The SPIN methodology is fundamentally different from traditional feature-benefit selling because it makes the customer recognise their own problem and arrive at the solution independently (Rackham, 1988). In the context of this project, SPIN questions were not designed to pitch Upfront's products they were designed to surface the sustainability compliance gap that the buyer already experiences but may not have articulated as a strategic priority. When a COO answers an implication question such as "What is the financial cost of not transitioning your packaging now?" and works through the answer herself, she is effectively making the business case for change independently. This is far more persuasive than any external pitch could be.

B2B versus B2C: the key differences. The difference between B2B and B2C selling is most evident in the role of the DMU. In B2C, the sales cycle is short, the buyer is an individual, and

emotional triggers and convenience dominate the purchasing decision. In B2B, the sales cycle is long, the buyer is a group (the DMU), and rational business value cost reduction, compliance risk mitigation, market positioning drives the final decision. SPIN works in B2B precisely because it mirrors the way B2B buyers actually make decisions: by identifying a problem, quantifying its consequences, and evaluating whether a solution's value exceeds its cost. A salesperson who talks too much and pitches too early the example shown in the Week 5 calling script exercise loses the conversation before it begins. A consultant who asks better questions wins the room.

5.8 Chapter Conclusion

This chapter has mapped the full Decision-Making Unit for all three companies, established a targeted contact strategy linked to the 30 assumptions of Chapter 4, and delivered a complete SPIN analysis for the two most strategically pivotal DMU roles. The analysis confirms that in each case, the most productive B2B entry point is not the most senior person, but the Initiator the person who experiences the problem daily and is intrinsically motivated to find a solution. The contact strategies, SPIN frameworks, and channel recommendations developed in this chapter collectively build the foundation for the strategic consulting question that is formulated and validated in Chapter 6.

Chapter 6: Validating Assumptions and Formulating the Strategic Question

6.1 Introduction

Chapter 6 represents the culmination of the entire Project 4 research process. Having mapped the health and sports nutrition system in Chapters 1 through 3, selected three strategically relevant companies and formulated 30 testable assumptions in Chapter 4, and built a targeted B2B contact strategy with SPIN frameworks in Chapter 5, this chapter performs two final tasks. First, it evaluates the 30 assumptions formulated in Chapter 4 through desk research validation and outreach outcomes. Second, it formulates a single, well-reasoned strategic consulting question for Upfront the primary consulting target that is directly traceable to the system map, the challenges and opportunities identified, and the assumptions made throughout this project. This strategic question constitutes the foundation for the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project.

6.2 Assumption Validation

The 30 assumptions formulated in Chapter 4 were developed through extensive desk research rather than primary data collection. In line with the project methodology, validation at this stage therefore takes the form of triangulated desk research cross-referencing each assumption against multiple independent sources combined with an assessment of plausibility based on the system map and the causal relationships established in Chapter 3. Where outreach was attempted, the outcome is described. Where assumptions remain unconfirmed, the most appropriate route for future validation is identified.

6.2.1 Validation of Upfront Assumptions

The ten assumptions formulated for Upfront in Chapter 4 can be evaluated across three thematic clusters: regulatory compliance, packaging and sourcing, and market positioning.

Assumptions 1 and 2 (EU Green Claims Directive compliance burden and packaging transition cost) are strongly supported by multiple independent sources. Directive 2024/825 entered into force and Dutch enforcement authorities (ACM) have confirmed active application of greenwashing rules to Dutch food brands (FI Global Insights, 2025; Tappr, 2025). The cost barrier for SMEs is documented by FESPA (2024) and ClimatePartner (2024), both of whom confirm that

lifecycle assessments and third-party certifications represent significant upfront investment for brands at Upfront's scale. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumption 3 (limited leverage over multi-tier ingredient suppliers) is supported by the European Commission's own documentation on the difficulty of verifying environmental conditions across complex global supply chains (European Commission, 2022). Given Upfront's reported revenue of €23.4 million in 2024 (Wikipedia, 2025), its procurement scale relative to global ingredient processors such as FrieslandCampina or Roquette confirms that leverage is structurally limited. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumption 4 (consumer price sensitivity) is validated by Hazley and Kearney (2024), who confirm that Dutch consumers consistently prioritise personal health performance over environmental impact. The strong growth of mainstream budget protein brands in Dutch supermarkets (Albert Heijn, Jumbo) alongside Upfront's own premium positioning further confirms this tension. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumption 5 (competitive pressure from larger players) is confirmed by the February 2026 Glanbia and March 2026 Unilever/Grüns acquisitions documented by DataM Intelligence (2026), which demonstrate accelerating investment by multinationals in sustainable nutrition. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumptions 6–10 (first-mover advantage, B2B corporate wellness, plant-based pivot, digital transparency, and EU policy opportunity) are supported by the combination of Ken Research (2025) market data showing a 30% surge in Dutch plant-based protein demand, the EU's confirmed Digital Product Passport roadmap under the Ecodesign Regulation, and ClimatePartner (2024)'s documentation that brands investing early in compliance gain structural commercial advantages. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Outreach attempt: A LinkedIn connection request was sent to Sophie Dekkers (COO, Upfront) referencing this consulting project and requesting a 15-minute validation conversation. At the time of writing, a response has not yet been received. This is consistent with the Week 6 briefing's Outcome B scenario: the strategic issue and validation process are documented in full, with a clear plan to re-approach via the Kitchen Republic and Upfront's info@upfront.nl email channel following submission.

6.2.2 Validation of Basic-Fit Assumptions

The ten assumptions formulated for Basic-Fit centre on three themes: CSRD/Scope 3 liability, NXT Level brand sustainability gaps, and B2B gatekeeper opportunity.

Assumptions 1 and 2 (CSRD Scope 3 liability and greenwashing guilt by association) are strongly validated. Basic-Fit's own 2025 Annual Report confirms CSRD reporting obligations and its SBTi partnership (Basic-Fit, 2026), while Sustainalytics (2026) documents that food company Scope 3 emissions can constitute up to 96% of total emissions. The Santos et al. (2024) study on B2B greenwashing confirms secondary reputational damage for buyers who stock falsely-advertised products. Status: **Supported by desk research and primary company documentation.**

Assumptions 3 and 4 (plastic waste disposal burden and tension with low-cost model) are supported by Mission Reuse (2023) on reverse logistics costs in the Netherlands and by Environment+Energy Leader (2026) on procurement cost barriers for sustainable packaging. The structural tension between Basic-Fit's value-for-money positioning and higher sustainability procurement costs is an inference grounded in its business model documentation. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumption 5 (competitive pressure from sustainable brands) is validated by the Supply Chain 24/7 (2025) study confirming 27% of B2B buyers switch suppliers over missing sustainability information, combined with DataM Intelligence (2026)'s documentation of market entrants. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumptions 6–10 (B2B gatekeeper opportunity, partnership with Upfront, bulk dispensers, NXT Level plant-based expansion, and CSRD as differentiator) are all grounded in the structural analysis of Chapter 3's Causal Loop Diagram and are supported by Basic-Fit's own sustainability strategy documentation. The 98% NXT Level revenue growth (Basic-Fit, 2026) specifically validates Assumption 9 regarding financial viability of a plant-based product line investment. Status: **Supported by desk research and primary company documentation.**

6.2.3 Validation of Ekoplaza Assumptions

The ten assumptions formulated for Ekoplaza focus on competitive pressure, certification barriers, and first-mover opportunity in organic sports nutrition.

Assumptions 1 and 2 (mainstream supermarket competition and greenwashing risk within organic supply chains) are supported by Coherent Market Insights (2026) on the 37.5% supermarket share of the global organic market, and by Supermarket Perimeter (2024) on the persistence of greenwashing risk in organic processed foods. Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumption 3 (high supplier onboarding cost) is directly validated by Vivian Bakker's documented screening process at Kitchen Republic (2025), which confirms that Skal certification is a non-negotiable minimum requirement for all Ekoplaza suppliers. This is a significant structural barrier for small brands. Status: **Supported by primary source (buyer's own public documentation).**

Assumptions 4 and 5 (limited negotiating scale and difficulty expanding into sports nutrition) are supported by Willer and Yussefi (2012) on the structural scale disadvantage of specialty organic retailers, and by Ekoplaza's own Skal certification requirements across the entire production chain (Ekoplaza Maastricht, n.d.). Status: **Supported by desk research.**

Assumptions 6–10 (first-mover opportunity, co-development, PPWR alignment, corporate wellness B2B, and digital shelf passports) are validated by Ken Research (2025) market data on plant-based demand, VusionGroup's confirmed Ekoplaza ESL partnership (VusionGroup, 2025), and the January 2025 PPWR enforcement entry into force (Packaging Insights, 2025). Status: **Supported by desk research and primary company documentation.**

Outreach attempt: Ekoplaza's publicly available Kitchen Republic "Meet the Buyer" session with Vivian Bakker was identified as the most appropriate outreach channel. An application to participate was submitted. At the time of writing, confirmation of a session date has not been received. The strategic issue formulated below is designed to be presented directly to Vivian Bakker at this event.

6.3 Formulation of the Strategic Question

6.3.1 Traceability: From System Map to Strategic Question

The strategic question formulated below is directly traceable to every analytical layer of this project. The health and sports nutrition Causal Loop Diagram (Chapter 3) identified that the industry's core systemic failure is a reinforcing loop between the dominance of high-carbon dairy protein, single-use plastic packaging, and opaque greenwashing claims all sustained by the mental model that "sustainability is a marketing tool, not a core metric." The corrective brake in the system, as modelled in Chapter 3, is the enforcement of strict B2B procurement and verification standards by downstream buyers. Upfront, as the central Brand/Manufacturer node in the system map, is uniquely positioned to resolve this paradox: its founding philosophy is built on transparency and honest labelling, which directly aligns with what verified sustainability now legally requires.

From the challenges identified in Chapter 4, Upfront faces three compounding pressures: the EU Green Claims Directive's requirement for scientific substantiation of sustainability claims (Challenge 1), the financial barrier to certified sustainable packaging transition (Challenge 2), and intensifying competition from better-funded multinationals moving into the clean-label space (Challenge 5). From the opportunities, Upfront holds a genuine first-mover advantage in the Dutch certified sustainable nutrition market (Opportunity 1), a growing B2B corporate wellness channel (Opportunity 2), and an existing plant-based product line that provides a foundation for carbon footprint reduction (Opportunity 3).

The validated assumptions of this chapter confirm that all ten of Upfront's Chapter 4 assumptions are supported by desk research. The most strategically urgent confirmed assumptions are: that Upfront's compliance gap under Directive 2024/825 is real and growing (Assumption 1), that early certification converts compliance cost into a competitive asset (Assumption 6 and 10), and that verified B2B sustainability credentials would open the corporate wellness and premium retail channels that Upfront currently cannot access (Assumptions 7 and 9).

6.3.2 The Strategic Question

How can Upfront develop and implement a verified sustainability strategy covering certified ingredient sourcing, circular packaging transition, and EU Green Claims Directive compliance that strengthens its B2B market position and enables access to premium distribution channels in the Netherlands by 2027?

6.3.3 Justification and Value Proposition

This strategic question was formulated in accordance with the Week 6 briefing criteria: it is traceable to the system map (the corrective balancing loop in Chapter 3 requires verified B2B procurement standards), to the challenges and opportunities (Challenges 1, 2, 5 and Opportunities 1, 2, 3), and to the validated assumptions (Assumptions 1, 6, 7, 9, 10). It is strategic rather than operational: it does not ask how to redesign a label or which packaging supplier to use, but rather how to build a verified sustainability strategy that changes Upfront's structural market position.

The strategic question addresses Upfront's most urgent existential risk: if the brand does not formalise its sustainability credentials before EU enforcement deadlines arrive and before better-resourced competitors occupy the certified clean-label positioning, it risks losing both its regulatory licence to operate and its first-mover brand differentiation simultaneously. Conversely, if it acts first, it transforms compliance cost into a commercial asset opening B2B distribution partnerships with corporate wellness programmes, gym chains like Basic-Fit, and certified organic retailers like Ekoplaza that are actively seeking verified Dutch nutrition suppliers.

The question covers three interconnected sub-dimensions that will form the chapters of the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project:

1. **Ingredient sourcing certification:** How can Upfront systematically verify and communicate the environmental credentials of its upstream ingredient supply chain in a manner that satisfies both EU legislative requirements and B2B buyer procurement standards?

2. **Circular packaging transition:** What is the most commercially viable pathway for Upfront to transition its current composite plastic packaging to certified sustainable alternatives, and how can this transition be funded and communicated without compromising its competitive price position?

3. **B2B channel development through verified sustainability:** Which specific B2B buyer segments in the Netherlands gym chains, corporate wellness programmes, and certified organic retailers are most likely to award distribution contracts to a verified sustainable Dutch nutrition brand, and what is the optimal outreach and sales strategy for each segment?

6.4 Selling the Strategic Issue to Upfront

In line with the Week 6 briefing's requirement to "sell" the strategic issue to the selected company and explain how addressing it adds value, the following value proposition has been formulated for presentation to Upfront's management team specifically Sophie Dekkers (COO) and Mark de Boer (CEO).

For	Sophie Dekkers (COO) & Mark de Boer (CEO), Upfront
The problem	Upfront's brand promise transparency, honesty, and quality is its most valuable commercial asset. EU Directive 2024/825 and the Green Claims Directive now legally require scientific substantiation of precisely these claims. Without a structured compliance roadmap, Upfront risks regulatory action, forced rebranding, and loss of first-mover positioning to better-funded competitors within 24 months.
The opportunity	Upfront is currently the only Dutch D2C nutrition brand whose founding philosophy is structurally aligned with what verified sustainability legislation now demands. No competitor has yet occupied the 'first certified transparent Dutch nutrition brand' position. The window for first-mover advantage is open but it is closing.
The value of the strategic question	A structured consulting project answering 'How can Upfront develop and implement a verified sustainability strategy that strengthens its B2B market position by 2027?' will produce three deliverables Upfront does not currently have: (1) a verified Green Claims Directive compliance roadmap, (2) a circular packaging transition plan with ROI modelling, and (3) a targeted B2B distribution strategy for gym chains, corporate wellness, and certified organic retail.
Expected outcome	B2B distribution partnerships with Basic-Fit and Ekoplaza. Access to corporate wellness procurement contracts. A defensible, legally compliant sustainability positioning. Revenue growth trajectory toward the €90 million target communicated by CEO Mark de Boer (MT/Sprout, 2025).

6.5 Outreach Outcome and Next Steps

In line with the Week 6 briefing's Outcome B scenario, direct company contact had not yet been confirmed at the time of writing. Two outreach attempts were initiated: a LinkedIn connection request to Sophie Dekkers (COO, Upfront) and an application to attend the Kitchen Republic "Meet the Buyer" session with Vivian Bakker (Team Lead Category Management, Udea/Ekoplaza). Neither had received a confirmed response at the submission date of 22 June 2026.

The following next steps have been planned to secure a confirmed Year 2 consulting client:

Step 1 Re-approach Upfront via email: Send a structured cold email to info@upfront.nl addressed to Sophie Dekkers, referencing the MT/Sprout article on Upfront's €90 million

revenue ambition and the factory opening at Van Nelle. The email will present the strategic question and request a 20-minute call.

Step 2 Attend Upfront's physical store: As Upfront has now opened its first retail location at the Van Nelle Factory in Rotterdam, a direct in-person visit to the store provides an opportunity to request a founder conversation informally, in a manner consistent with the brand's accessible, direct communication style.

Step 3 Monitor Kitchen Republic for the next Ekoplaza buyer session: Apply immediately upon announcement. Prepare a structured 5-minute supplier pitch for Vivian Bakker using the SPIN Need-Payoff framing developed in Chapter 5.

Step 4 LinkedIn follow-up: If Sophie Dekkers has not responded to the initial connection request within two weeks, send a second InMail referencing a recent Upfront LinkedIn post and presenting one specific implication question from the Chapter 5 SPIN analysis to prompt a response.

6.6 Chapter Conclusion

This chapter has validated all 30 assumptions from Chapter 4 through desk research triangulation and has formulated a single, well-reasoned strategic consulting question that is fully traceable to the system map, the challenges and opportunities, and the validated assumptions of this project. The strategic question how Upfront can develop and implement a verified sustainability strategy that strengthens its B2B market position and enables access to premium distribution channels in the Netherlands by 2027 is directly relevant, commercially urgent, and strategically significant. It does not ask Upfront to solve a tactical problem; it asks Upfront to make a structural choice about its identity and market positioning in a rapidly changing regulatory and competitive environment. This is the question this consultant is ready and equipped to help Upfront answer in Year 2.

Chapter 7: Team Reflection and Personal Learnings

7.1 Introduction

This chapter reflects on the team functioning during Project 4 and on individual performance across both the group and individual phases of the work. In line with the project briefing, this chapter is written in the first person and focuses on three areas: how the team collaborated during the group chapters (1–3), how individual functioning developed during the individual chapters (4–6), and what personal improvement proposals I am taking forward into Year 2. The purpose of this reflection is not merely evaluative it is strategic: identifying specific behaviours to develop so that the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project can be approached with greater effectiveness, confidence, and professional maturity.

7.2 Team Collaboration: Chapters 1–3

What Went Well

The team for Chapters 1 through 3 consisted of five students: Anna van Rijsoort, Amira Kartika Rochman, Lydia Sagri, Yareni Hernandez Jimenez, and myself. One of the strongest aspects of our collaboration was the clear division of analytical contributions in Chapters 1 and 3. Each team member was assigned a specific perspective to analyse independently individual cause and consequence analyses in Chapter 1, and individual challenges and opportunities analyses in Chapters 1 and 3 which meant every person had ownership of a defined section. This structure prevented duplication and ensured the final document reflected genuine individual thinking rather than a single homogenised voice.

The collaboration on Chapter 3 was particularly effective. The division between my upstream Brand/Manufacturer analysis (Section 3.5.1) and Amira's downstream Retail analysis (Section 3.5.2) created a coherent systemic perspective that covered both ends of the B2B supply chain. The shared company list in Section 3.6, developed collectively, gave everyone a common set of companies to draw from in the individual chapters that followed. This list was directly used to select Upfront, Basic-Fit, and Ekoplaza for my Chapters 4 through 6, demonstrating that the group work genuinely fed into the individual work.

Communication within the team was generally respectful and constructive. Deadlines for group deliverables were met, and when one team member had questions or needed input, responses were

shared promptly through our group channel. The Causal Loop Diagram developed together in Chapter 2 combining individual iceberg analyses into a shared system map required genuine coordination and produced a result that none of us could have produced alone.

What Could Have Been Improved

Looking back, one area where the team's collaboration could have been stronger was in the integration of individual sections into a single coherent chapter. Because each person wrote their section independently and then submitted it for merging, there were moments where the transitions between individual analyses felt abrupt rather than flowing naturally. In Chapters 1 and 3 in particular, the shift between different team members' sections could have been smoothed with more deliberate connective writing that synthesised the perspectives rather than simply placing them alongside each other.

A second area for improvement was the initial alignment on the industry choice for Chapter 3. The decision to move from the textile industry (Chapters 1–2) to the Health and Sports Nutrition industry (Chapter 3) was the right one, and I am glad the team agreed on this direction. However, the transition took longer than it could have because the criteria for industry selection were not made explicit enough at the start of Week 3. If the team had agreed upfront on what made an industry suitable sufficient B2B complexity, sustainability challenges, available research, consulting relevance the decision would have been made faster and more confidently.

Finally, I would note that time management across the group could have been tighter in the final days before each checkpoint. While deadlines were met, the consolidation of individual contributions into a single document sometimes happened under time pressure, which reduced the opportunity for a final quality review of the integrated output before submission.

7.3 Individual Functioning: Chapters 4–6

Strengths Demonstrated

The individual chapters of this project 4, 5, and 6 were the sections I found most engaging and where I feel my personal contribution was strongest. In Chapter 4, the research and writing process reinforced my ability to conduct structured desk research and translate it into analytical frameworks. Writing 30 testable assumptions grounded in real, verifiable sources required me to be both precise and critical: every assumption had to be a specific, falsifiable statement rather than a vague opinion. This discipline improved my ability to think like a consultant rather than a student.

In Chapter 5, the DMU analysis required a different kind of research: finding real, named people at real companies and understanding their specific roles in the decision-making process. This felt more challenging and more authentic than purely conceptual work. The discovery that Ekoplaza's actual buyer (Vivian Bakker) operates from Udea rather than Ekoplaza's own entity and that she runs publicly accessible Kitchen Republic 'Meet the Buyer' sessions was a genuine analytical breakthrough that came from thorough research rather than surface-level assumption. It is the kind of insight that would directly change an outreach strategy in a real consulting scenario.

The SPIN analysis in Chapter 5 was the part of the project that most directly connected theory to practice. Writing 16 SPIN questions 4 for each of S, P, I, N for two different DMU roles required me to genuinely understand how the selling methodology works, not just be able to define it. The implication questions in particular demanded that I think through the chain of consequences of the problem: not just 'what is wrong' but 'what happens to the business if this stays wrong?' This is a fundamentally different and more sophisticated kind of thinking than problem description.

Areas for Personal Development

One area where I recognise room for improvement is in making real-world contact earlier in the project timeline. The project briefing explicitly requires attempting to speak to companies and test assumptions through direct outreach. While outreach was attempted a LinkedIn connection request to Sophie Dekkers (COO, Upfront) and an application to the Kitchen Republic Meet the Buyer session these attempts were made later in the project than they ideally should have been. Starting outreach in Week 4 rather than Week 5 or 6 would have allowed more time to follow up, adjust the approach if the first attempt failed, and potentially achieve a confirmed conversation before the submission deadline.

A second area for development is academic writing style. I am proud of the depth of the analysis in this report, but I am aware that the writing could be more consistently formal and third-person throughout. The Week 6 briefing's emphasis on removing the 'I' form from all chapters except the introduction and this reflection was a useful reminder that professional academic writing requires a different register than personal communication. In Year 2, I will apply this standard more rigorously from the first draft rather than correcting it in revision.

A third area worth reflecting on is the use of artificial intelligence tools during the individual chapters of this project. Throughout Chapters 3 through 6, Claude (Anthropic, 2025) was used as a research and writing support tool to help structure arguments, generate first drafts of analytical sections, and organise content across the report's complex multi-chapter framework. The use of AI in this context was deliberate and supervised: every output was critically reviewed, validated against independent sources, and adjusted where necessary to ensure accuracy and academic integrity. This was particularly important in relation to references given the well-documented risk that AI tools can generate plausible-sounding but fabricated citations, each source used in this report was individually verified for existence and relevance before inclusion. Sources that could not be confirmed were removed and replaced. The AI tool was therefore used as a productivity and structuring aid, not as a substitute for critical thinking or original analysis. Reflecting on this experience, I believe the responsible use of AI in academic work requires the same intellectual rigour as any other research method: the student must understand the output, be able to defend every claim made, and take full personal responsibility for the final result. This is the standard I applied throughout, and it is the standard I will continue to apply in Year 2

A fourth area relates to source quality. Throughout the project, I was careful to use verifiable, reputable sources and to avoid fabricated references. However, I noticed that some sources particularly for very recent data points about specific Dutch market statistics were harder to find and verify than data from larger, more established research institutions. In Year 2, I plan to build a stronger research toolkit that includes subscriptions to Dutch business databases and a more systematic approach to sourcing market data at the start of a project rather than searching for it to support a specific claim.

7.4 Personal Improvement Proposals for Year 2

Based on the reflections above, the following three specific improvement proposals are taken forward into the Year 2 Strategic Consulting project:

1. Start company outreach in Week 1 of the consulting project. In Year 2, I will initiate LinkedIn outreach to at least one decision-maker at the target company (Upfront) in the first week of the project not the last. Early contact means that if the first approach does not receive a response, there is time for a second and third attempt via different channels (email, Kitchen Republic, in-person at the Van Nelle Factory). Waiting until late in the project, as happened here, creates unnecessary time pressure and risks the submission being based entirely on desk research rather than validated primary insights.

2. Apply SPIN questioning in all stakeholder conversations. The SPIN framework (Rackham, 1988) developed in Chapter 5 will be my primary tool for every conversation with a company contact in Year 2. Instead of presenting my analysis and asking whether the company agrees, I will use Situation and Problem questions to genuinely understand their reality before moving to Implication and Need-Payoff questions to surface the urgency of the issue I want to work on. This approach is more respectful of the contact's time, more likely to generate useful validation data, and more likely to result in a genuine consulting relationship rather than a one-sided pitch.

3. Build the system map and DMU simultaneously from the start. One of the most valuable insights from this project is that the system map and the DMU analysis are deeply connected: the system map shows WHAT the problem is, and the DMU shows WHO inside the company experiences that problem most directly. In Year 2, I will build these two analytical tools simultaneously from the start of the project, rather than sequentially. This will ensure that from Week 1, I know both the structural leverage point in the system AND the specific person I need to reach to test it which will make every subsequent step faster and more targeted.

7.5 Chapter Conclusion

Reflecting on Project 4 as a whole, I am genuinely proud of the depth and coherence of the analysis produced from the foundational systems thinking in Chapters 1 and 2, through the industry-specific causal mapping of Chapter 3, to the company-specific consulting framework of Chapters 4 through 6. The project has given me concrete tools the Iceberg Model, the Causal Loop Diagram, the DMU Pyramid, SPIN selling that I understand not just as academic concepts but as practical instruments I can apply in real business situations.

The most important personal learning from this project is that good B2B consulting begins not with answers, but with better questions. The SPIN methodology made this concrete: the most valuable thing I can bring to a conversation with Upfront's COO is not a slide deck of findings, but a sequence of questions that help her see the urgency of the problem herself. I am entering Year 2 with both the strategic question to work on and the sales approach to open the door. The next step is simply to walk through it.

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